

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

The event was scheduled from 3 pm to 6 pm and was to be organised by the Jawaharlal Nehru University Students' Union (JNUSU) as a public discussion marking Tribal Day, or Adivasi Diwas. The JNU administration cited

Noble is hereby given to the General Public that Her Majesty's Patent Office has accepted for filing by the Applicant, Rajiv Private Limited (formerly known as Arrow Infrastructure Private Limited), having its registered office at Plot No. 60, Sector-7, Gurgaon, Haryana, India, Title "H1020 ("The Owner"), has approached us for conducting title due diligence and issuing a Title Search Report/Title Certificate certifying that the immovable properties situated in the villages Bahadur Kharanji & Panchayanspur & Shehanatshah Pargana Tehsil District Hardwar, Uttarakhand, and village Anekli Haridwar village Salempur Mahud Part-II, Tehsil and District Hardwar, Uttarakhand, have a clear, marketable and mortgageable title for the purpose of creation of security by way of mortgage in favour of IndusInd Bank Ltd.

During the course of scrutiny and verification of the title documents relating to the said properties situated in District Hardwar, Uttarakhand, it has been represented to us by the Owner that certain original documents pertaining to said properties are missing, particulars where mentioned below, and such misplaced/done and, despite diligent search and efforts, the same could not be traced:

1. Original registered Sale Deed dated 24.06.2008 registered in bahi No. 1 Zild No. 342 pages 197-208 Document no. 2754 dated 24.06.2008 in the office of Sub-Registrar Roorkee, executed by Shri Islam S/o Shri Ibrahim Ali R/o village Bharapura Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee Dist Hardwar in favor of Aarow Infrastructure Pvt Limited.
2. Original registered Sale Deed dated 25.09.2008 in the office of Sub-Registrar Roorkee, executed by Shri Sukh Ram S/o Shri Bakshi R/o village Bhaupur Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee Dist Hardwar in favor of Aarow Infrastructure Pvt Limited.
3. Original registered Sale Deed dated 25.09.2008 in the office of Sub-Registrar Roorkee, executed by Shri Sukh Ram S/o Shri Bakshi R/o village Bhaupur Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee, Dist Hardwar in favor of Aarow Infrastructure Pvt Limited.
4. Original registered Sale Deed dated 24.06.2008 in the office of Sub-Registrar Roorkee, executed by Shri Sukh Ram S/o Shri Bakshi R/o village Bhaupur Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee Dist Hardwar in favor of Aarow Infrastructure Pvt Limited.
5. Original registered Sale Deed dated 06.06.2008 in the office of Sub-Registrar Roorkee, executed by Shri Jagpal Singh S/o Shri Gutesh Singh R/o village Govindpur Wazidpur Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee Dist Hardwar in favor of Aarow Infrastructure Pvt Limited.
6. Original registered Sale Deed dated 19.04.2007 registered in bahi No. 1 Zild No. 288 pages 1-28 Document no. 1810 dated 19.04.2008 in the office of Sub-Registrar Roorkee executed by Shri Harkan Pargana S/o Shri Ibrahim r/o village Bharapura Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee, Dist Hardwar in favor of Aarow Infrastructure Pvt Limited.
7. Original registered Sale Deed dated 15.03.2007 in the office of Sub-Registrar Roorkee executed by Shri Kundan Devi S/o Shri Hukam Chand Jain R/o village Badheri Rajpura Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee Dist Hardwar in favor of Aarow Infrastructure Pvt Limited.
8. Original registered Sale Deed dated 15.03.2007 registered in bahi No. 1 Zild No. 287 pages 1-166 Document no. 1810 dated 26.04.2008 in the office of Sub-Registrar Roorkee executed by Shri Harkan Pargana S/o Shri Midda R/o village Badheri Rajpura Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee, Dist Hardwar in favor of Aarow Infrastructure Pvt Limited.
9. Original registered Sale Deed dated 05.03.2007 in the office of Sub-Registrar Roorkee, executed by Shri Kundan Devi S/o Shri Hukam Chand Jain R/o village Badheri Rajpura Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee, Dist Hardwar in favor of Aarow Infrastructure Pvt Limited.
10. 07.04.2007 in the office of Sub-Registrar Roorkee, executed by Smt. Raj Rania W/o Shri Ratan Lal Gupta r/o 73, East Rajpura Roorkee Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee, Dist Hardwar in favor of Aarow Infrastructure Pvt Limited.
11. Original registered Sale Deed dated 01.05.2008 in the office of Sub-Registrar Roorkee, executed by Sh. Sudesh Kumar and Sh. Ravindra Kumar s/o Sh. Prem Prakash both r/o village Alampur Bangla, Tehsil and Dist. Hardwar and Smt. Shyam Bai W/o Ashanand r/o Anaz Mand Kameshwar, Tehsil and Dist. Hardwar and Smt. Jwalesh W/o Sh. Prem Lal R/o K-31, Shivkalya Nagar Pargana and Tehsil Roorkee Dist Hardwar in favor of Aarow Infrastructure Pvt Limited.

For Project Gauradanda, Hardwar

1. Original Sale Deed dated 16/11/2007 executed by Jagdish Kumar in favour of M/s Arrows Infrastructure Ltd with respect to land measuring 2.2051 Hect. comprised in Kharsa No. 1494/1, 0.537 Hect. comprised in Kharsa No. 1549/1 situated in the revenue estate of Village Sasamand, Mahud Part-II, Tehsil & District Hardwar, Uttarakhand and registered as Document No. 1611. Additional Book No. 1, registered on 16/11/2007.

For Project Greens, Hardwar

1. Original Sale Deed dated 07/03/2008 executed by Pramod Kumar in favour of M/s Arrow Infrastructure Ltd with respect to and land measuring 0.071 Hect. comprised in Kharsa No. 1439/1, 0.071 Hect. comprised in Kharsa No. 1439/2, 0.071 Hect. comprised in Kharsa No. 1439/3, and 0.071 Hect. comprised in Kharsa No. 1445/5M situated in the revenue estate of Village Anekli Hatampur, Tehsil & District Haridwar, Uttarakhand and registered as Document No. 1611. Additional Book No. 1, registered on 07/03/2008.

It has further been represented to us by the Owner that, upon discovering the loss of the aforesaid original title documents, a complaint regarding the missing/sold documents was lodged with the Police Station, the Industrial Area, District South Eastern, Delhi, Crime Branch, Delhi, vide I.R. No. 46739/32 dated 21-07-2027.

The Landowner has represented and confirmed that the aforesaid original title documents have been genuinely lost/misplaced and, despite diligent efforts remain untraceable. The Landowner has further affirmed that, said documents have not been pledged, deposited, assigned, transferred, or otherwise disposed of, or are not a mortgage, charge, lien, encumbrance, security interest, or any other third-party right or interest whatsoever in respect of the said documents or the immovable properties to which they relate.

Any person(s), bank(s), financial institution(s), company(ies), authority(ies) or any other entity having any right, title, interest, charge, mortgage, lien, encumbrance, security interest, or any other whatsoever nature in respect of the aforesaid properties or claiming to be in possession of the aforesaid original documents, or having any information regarding the same, is hereby called upon to submit such claim or objection, together with supporting documentary evidence, to the undersigned (hereinafter "Seven") days from the date of receipt of this Notice.

In the event no claim, objection or information is received within the aforesaid period, it shall be presumed that no person has any right, title, interest, claim or objection in respect of the said properties or the aforesaid missing original documents, and the title due diligence process and issuance of the Title Search Report/Certificate shall proceed on the basis of the said documents and information made available to us, without any further reference to any person.

Dated this 7th day of August, 2026.

Sunil Salooja (Advocate)
For Salooja & Associates
Advocates & Solicitors
B-2/10, Janak Puri, New Delhi-110058
Email: ssalooja2002@gmail.com
Phone: 9811124280

"JNU is a democratic and decentralised institution. The permission was given by the Dean, SSS, who has taken action as well in cancelling the event," the university said. "The booking of the auditorium SSS-1 stands cancelled because of non-

The booking request had been filed by Dr Avinash Kumar of JNU's Centre for Informal Sector and Labour Studies (CISLS), School of Social Sciences, describing the purpose of the event on the official form as a 'Public

Talk for Adivasi Diwas (Book Discussion).' The form was countersigned by the Dean of the School of Social Sciences on August 7, 2026, and the Dealing Assistant had confirmed the auditorium's availability for the date, with a note that the booking be

According to an event's poster circulated, the event was to take place at the SSS-1 auditorium of the university on August 10, from 3 pm onwards. As per the poster, the guest speakers were

ABVP JNU President Mayank Panchal said, "The campus of

The discussion on the book “Fractured Communities: Adivasi Histories and the

The JNUSU, in a statement, claimed that the Dean of the School of Social Sciences had himself instructed that the auditorium booking be made in the format in which it was submitted and questioned the administration's explanation for the cancellation. The union also alleged "double standards", claiming that the administration had extended cooperation and space on campus for ISKCON events while denying a venue for the book discussion.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

Delhi BJP 1
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Manjinder Singh Sirsa and Saurabh Bharadwaj

He further claimed that the arrangement was

become politically frustrated
and are making irresponsible

The Delhi BJP spokesperson said that Delhi Government Minister Sardar Manjinder Singh Sirsa, in an X post today, stated that once again, AAP Delhi Convenor Saurabh Bharadwaj and MLA Sanjeev Jha attempted to level false and baseless allegations against the Delhi Government through a press conference. However, the people of Delhi no longer have any faith in them.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

"The campaign will also identify and expose organised gangs forcing children into begging," she said, asking people to provide their comments and sugges-

tions on the campaign.

begging. The other is the involvement of organised gangs who force small homeless and poor children into begging, which will require strict legal action," Vyas said.

According to estimates by social organisations, there are around 70,000 street children in the capital, of which thousands are engaged in begging at public places, including around religious sites, bus and metro stations, markets and major road intersections.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The yatra will take place under the leadership of Members of Parliament and senior party leaders, with

Malhotra announcing he will personally lead the Chandigarh Chowk district march on Monday.

The campaign is being coordinated under the guidance of State General Secretary Vishnu Mittal, and

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

According to a Delhi Police statement on Sunday, Jansunwai or public hearing programmes were held at police stations across the city on August 1. Police said 368 complaints

"The presence of senior officers during the hearings is aimed at expediting grievance redressal, strengthening accountability and enhancing public confidence in police," the statement said.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

During the investigation, the girl was brought back on February 24, 2018, and medically examined. In her statement, she said Sagar was her boyfriend and that she had eloped with him, police said. She went “missing” again

Transit remand was obtained from a court following which Sagar was brought to Delhi and produced before a duty magistrate. He was subsequently sent to

During interrogation, Nagar said he had eloped with the minor when she was 16 and later married her. He said he worked as a vegetable vendor and lived with her as her husband.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

Renowned litterateur Dr Vinod Babbar, school chairman Dr Ved Tandon, principal Dr Vandana Tandon and former Deputy Director SK Saraswat presented them with awards at a

Dr Tandon said that two school students, Divyansh Ojha and Hardik Nautiyal, have secured admission to IIT Roorkee, while Rachit Fanin has been selected for IIT Delhi.

Delhi Metro sets new benchmark with 99.95% punctuality in 2026

RAJESH KUMAR
■ New Delhi

Delhi Metro has achieved a punctuality rate of 99.95 per cent in 2026, setting a new benchmark for the network, placing it ahead of the Hong Kong MTR, the Paris Metro and the New York subway in reliability and timeliness.

In Delhi Metro, a train is considered delayed if it reaches its destination more than 59 seconds after its scheduled arrival time, while many metro systems classify a delay only after several minutes. The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) operates

the country's longest metro network, covering 416.5 km with 303 stations across 12 lines. The network has 31 interchange stations connecting Delhi with the National Capital Region (NCR).

According to Anuj Dayal, Principal Executive Director, Corporate Communications, Delhi Metro, train punctuality, which was 98.27 per cent in 2003, climbed to 99.64 per cent in 2005, enabling DMRC to join the elite league of metro systems, achieving over 99 per cent punctuality within just two years of operation. Thereafter, DMRC has constantly achieved 99.9 per

cent train punctuality, year after year. Train headway has reduced from seven minutes in the early years to just 2 minutes 18 seconds on the busiest corridors.

The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation said daily ridership has risen substantially from around 82,000 passenger journeys in its first year of operation to an average of 64.06 lakh journeys currently. The network recorded its highest single-day ridership of more than 81 lakh passenger journeys on August 8, 2025.

"Generally, as the network and fleet length increase



along with maintenance issues with passage of time, the punctuality and reliability of the Metro system is

impacted adversely.

However, in its 23 years of operations so far, Delhi Metro has defied this norm by main-

taining a punctuality which stands at 99.95 per cent in 2026," he said.

Punctuality and reliability go hand in hand. DMRC has achieved a Mean Distance Between Failures (MDBF) of 2.72 million car-kilometres, a key indicator that measures the average distance travelled by Metro trains before a service affecting failure occurs. Through international benchmarking by the Community of Metros (COMET)-a consortium of 45 leading metro systems worldwide- in terms of reliability, Delhi Metro has consistently ranked among the top five

metro systems globally (based on the 2-minute delay criterion).

In addition, DMRC also operates India's largest driverless metro network, with about 29 per cent of the network running under Unattended Train Operation (UTO). Line 7, spanning 71.55 km with 45 stations, is the world's longest driverless metro line and one of the longest circular metro lines globally. It interchanges with every Delhi Metro corridor except a small portion of the Grey Line. The line has significantly reduced interchange congestion in the city's core,

created an integrated multi-route network, shortened passenger travel times, and provided alternate routing that strengthens operational resilience during service disruptions.

Delhi Metro began its journey on 25th December 2002 — an 8.4 km corridor between Shahdara and Tis Hazari with just 6 stations. Daily ridership has surged from nearly 82,000 passengers in its first year to a record single-day patronage of over 81 lakh passenger journeys on 8 August 2025, with average daily ridership reaching 64.06 lakh journeys.

Facial recognition, fingerprint screening: Police tighten security ahead of Independence Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Red Fort has been placed under a multi-layered security cover ahead of the Independence Day celebrations, with the Delhi Police deploying advanced technologies, including the Abhigyan app and facial recognition system (FRS) vans, to identify suspicious and wanted persons in the crowd, officers said.

The security arrangements have been strengthened amid intelligence inputs. Around 15,000-20,000 Delhi Police and paramilitary personnel are expected to be deployed for the August 15 celebrations. Nearly 25,000 people, including VIPs and VVIPs, are expected to attend the event at the Red Fort.

For the first time as part of the enhanced security arrangements, the Abhigyan application is being used extensively to screen people in the crowd, the officers said. The application has a database of more than one crore criminals, and police personnel are using hand-held devices to collect finger-



A security official passes by as preparations are underway ahead of the Independence Day amid rainfall at Red Fort in New Delhi

prints of randomly selected persons, they added.

The fingerprint is checked against the database within seconds. A red indication means the person has a criminal record, with details appearing on the screen, while a green indication indicates that no criminal record has been found.

Officials further said that nearly 1,000 CCTV cameras, including facial recognition system-enabled cameras, have been installed to monitor the Red Fort and its surroundings.

deployed in the area. Equipped with high-resolution cameras, the vans scan faces in the crowd and match them against available databases. If a wanted or suspicious person is detected, the system generates an alert and sends the information to the control room for immediate verification and necessary action.

A senior officer of the North District Computer Cell said the use of Abhigyan and FRS technology was helping police identify suspicious persons in crowded areas.

"Abhigyan app and FRS technology are helping us significantly in identifying suspicious persons in the crowd. This has further strengthened security," he said. The arrangements are being carried out under the Ministry of Home Affairs' smart policing initiative to ensure a safe and peaceful Independence Day celebration, he added.

This year's theme at the Red Fort is 'Vande Mataram'. Kite flying has been prohibited around the monument on August 15 as part of the security restrictions.

PWD Minister cites CAG report to allege ₹3,500 cr irregularities under previous Kejriwal Government

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Sunday cited the CAG report released on August 7, which covers the period up to March 31, 2023, to allege irregularities amounting to ₹3,500 crore under the previous Kejriwal Government.

The minister pointed to bogus e-way bills worth ₹68,680 crore generated by businesses with cancelled GST registrations, 1,185 manual tenders in violation of mandatory online tendering rules, and ₹42 crore in electricity subsidies allegedly released to consumers who were not residing at their homes.

Singh said 24 CAG reports have been received within 18 months of the present government, with each report exposing corruption involving thousands of crores of rupees.

He said that the latest August 7 report reveals the scale of irregularities across multiple departments during the Kejriwal Government's tenure. On GST irregularities, Singh alleged that



approximately ₹70,410 crore in tax revenue was outstanding from certain businesses in Delhi, and the Delhi Government had failed to recover it for more than five years. The CAG report found 8,334 businesses whose GST registrations had been cancelled yet continued to generate e-way bills, resulting in bogus e-way bills worth ₹68,680 crore.

Additionally, 4,076 non-filers continued generating e-way bills worth ₹11,635 crore. Singh said all this happened in collusion with the Kejriwal Government.

He said that out of 6.10 crore e-way bills, only 0.10 per cent were examined. Investigation into 70 cases found 344 instances of non-compliance involving a

revenue impact of ₹3,071.92 crore, while a turnover mismatch of ₹3,710.17 crore was also detected.

On electricity subsidies, Singh alleged that 50,000 consumers whose electricity bills remained zero for 12 consecutive months were nonetheless provided subsidies amounting to ₹17.81 crore. Around 90,000 consumers who had not been residing at their homes for six to eleven months received electricity subsidies worth ₹11.88 crore. He said a total of ₹42 crore was released from government funds in the name of power subsidies in such cases, and the matter would be investigated.

On manual tendering, Singh said the Kejriwal government conducted 1,185

manual tenders in violation of the mandatory requirement that all tenders be conducted online.

In these 1,185 tenders, 14,527 bids were received. He alleged that rates were effectively decided in a predetermined manner through mutual understanding among bidders. He said files related to contract awards were available in only 3 per cent of tenders, while files for the remaining 97 per cent were missing from Government records.

On the Baprola industrial land, Singh cited the CAG finding of ₹29.45 crore in unfruitful expenditure on 137.63 acres acquired for an industrial park, with 81.42 acres lying unused for 17 years and a ground rent of ₹15.79 crore remaining outstanding. On LNJP Hospital construction, Singh alleged that the cost per bed rose from an expected ₹33 lakh to ₹72 lakh after then-Minister Satyendar Jain repeatedly visited the construction site.

Singh said Kejriwal never allowed audits to be conducted during his tenure, and that is why ministers went to jail while he did not.

CM Rekha visits Kanwar camps in Mayapuri, Pitampura



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday visited Kanwar service camps in Mayapuri and Pitampura during the Sawan season on Sunday.

The Chief Minister welcomed and greeted Shiva devotees at both locations, showering flowers on Kanwariyas at the Mayapuri camp and distributing prasad, and reviewing the facilities and arrangements being provided to pilgrims carrying holy Ganga water from Haridwar.

At the Mayapuri camp, the Chief Minister interacted with Shiva devotees and enquired about their journeys. She reviewed the arrangements made at the camp and appreciated the dedication of the workers engaged in service. MLA Anil Sharma, MLA Umang Bajaj, former MP Ramesh Bidhuri, and a large number of Shiva devotees were present.

The Chief Minister said there is deep reverence across society for Kanwariyas who arrive in Delhi from Haridwar carrying holy Ganga water during the auspicious month of Sawan. "Like last year, Delhi is once again immersed in devotion to Baba Bhole, with Kanwar service camps set up across the city serving devotees with complete

dedication and commitment," she said.

At the Pitampura camp, the Chief Minister met devotees, and the workers engaged in their service and took stock of the facilities available. She said the Kanwar Yatra is a unique confluence of faith, devotion, discipline, and service and appreciated the work being carried out by various organisations and volunteers across Delhi to serve Shiva devotees.

She said the Delhi Government is committed to ensuring that every Shiva devotee passing through the capital gets a safe, smooth, and comfortable environment, and that the government and administration are working with full preparedness on the necessary arrangements during the Kanwar Yatra.

The Chief Minister added that the serving Shiva devotees is not merely a matter of logistics and arrangements but a responsibility rooted in faith and the spirit of service. She thanked all service committees, organisers, volunteers, and workers engaged in Kanwar service and appreciated their dedication.

She extended greetings to all Shiva devotees on the occasion of Sawan and prayed for a safe, successful, and auspicious journey for all Kanwariyas.

Frame rotation policy, transfer officials holding posts for long: LG to Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has been directed by Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu to formulate a policy for systematic rotation of officials and to transfer those holding same posts for longer duration, officials said on Sunday.

The directions were issued by the LG in a recent review of systems, processes and practices prevalent for over a decade, in a meeting with principal secretary (vigilance) of the Delhi Government.

The Delhi LG also instructed that the list of sensitive departments be reframed, after learning that while some departments with higher financial allocation were not included in the list of sensitive departments, others seemingly less sensitive ones were included in it, according to officials.

Further, Sandhu also directed that chief vigilance officers (CVOs) be immediately posted at all the sensitive departments for ensuring transparency and financial probity, officials said.

The standard mechanism



and operational guidelines need to be devised for CVOs, detailing how they should

supervise the adherence to the Chief Vigilance Commission (CVC) guide-

lines in contracts and tender processes, the LG said.

The vigilance department was asked to undertake regular meetings of departmental CVOs to review vigilance work, officials added.

Notably, the Delhi government had earlier carried out a wide-ranging reshuffle in GST department.

Officials who were posted in the same roles for extended periods were transferred to improve efficiency and accountability.

A total of 162 personnel were moved, including 3 Assistant Commissioners, 58

Section Officers (Grade I), 22 Assistant Section Officers (Grade II), 74 Senior Assistants (Grade III), and 5 Junior Assistants (Grade IV).

According to the officials, the action was part of a broader effort by the Delhi government to tighten discipline through surprise inspections and compliance checks across departments.

The Government had said that public service delivery standards cannot be compromised, and that accountability will apply uniformly across all levels of administration.



This pictorial representation of map of India does not purport to be the political map of India. Map not to scale.

ENHANCING MOBILITY

AS ONE OF INDIA'S LEADING ELECTRICAL AND ELECTRONICS COMPANIES.

As an established leader in automotive solutions, we are delivering continued growth and value.

- One of India's leading electrical & electronics (E&E) companies.*
- One of India's top 2 players in wiring harnesses for two & three wheelers.*
- A diversified presence across multiple end markets, including commercial vehicles, off-highway vehicles, farming & industrial equipment.
- 22 manufacturing facilities, 3 engineering and design support centers & 7 warehouses across India and globally.**
- Providing access to major automotive clusters both in India & the world over.

*Source: CRISIL Report | ** As of March 31, 2026



DHOOT TRANSMISSION
Harnessing Safety. Electrifying The Future

Dhoot Transmission Limited
www.dhoottransmission.com

Adfactors 230/26 C

IN FOCUS



An elephant splashes water over itself to escape the heat at National Zoological Park in New Delhi

PTI

ED Director Rahul Navin gets one-year extension

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre has extended the tenure of ED Director Rahul Navin by a year beyond August 13, a Government order said. A 1993-batch Indian Revenue Service officer of the Income Tax cadre, 59-year-old Navin has been leading the federal anti-money laundering agency as its chief since September 2023.

The order issued by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) on Saturday said it has approved extension in tenure of Navin as Enforcement Directorate (ED) Director for a period of one year beyond August 13, 2026, ie up to August 13, 2027, including extension in service beyond the date of his superannuation, i.e. July 31, 2027, or until further orders whichever is earlier. This is the first extension in



Day 16: JPSC protests force Govt to cancel...

Representatives of protesting students and a high-level committee constituted by the Jharkhand Government held a marathon meeting on Sunday. The discussions focused on the cancellation of disputed examinations, investigation into alleged financial and criminal irregularities, and reforms in the recruitment process.

After the day-long negotiations, Minister Sudivya Kumar Sonu said that the Government and the students had reached an agreement on nearly 98 per cent of the issues, while differences remained on around 2 per cent of the demands.

The minister further said that allegations involving financial transactions would be examined by the Enforcement Directorate (ED), while criminal aspects of the alleged irregularities would continue to be investigated by the CID. A fast-track court would also be constituted, with charge sheets against those found responsible to be filed within 90 days, he said.

On reforms in the recruitment system, Sonu said the Government would constitute an expert committee to examine the existing examination and recruitment mechanism and recommend reforms. The students have also demanded cancellation of all examinations conducted by TDPL, the agency engaged in conducting recruitment examinations, alleging serious irregularities in its functioning. The Government has not accepted this demand so far.

Speaking about the talks and the ongoing agitation, protesting student Manish Kumar said, "Jharkhand Government had listened seriously to their concerns and also given assurances. However, the students did not receive satisfactory assurances on the CGL examination and their demand for a CBI probe." He said that in the absence of a satisfactory resolution to these key demands, the students had been compelled to continue their agitation. The students have made it clear that the agitation will continue until all their demands are addressed. They are preparing for a march to the Jharkhand Assembly on Monday, with students from across the State expected to reach Ranchi to participate in the protest. The youth wing of the BJP has extended support to the proposed demonstration. The latest round of talks comes amid sustained protests by aspirants demanding greater transparency, accountability and an overhaul of the State's competitive examination system. Earlier, Chief Minister Hemant Soren today

Youth buried Congress: CM Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Siddharthnagar (UP)

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath asserted on Sunday that the youth of the nation have effectively "buried" the Congress party, and emphasised that the downfall of Congress serves as a clear example of the dangers of power intoxication.

"One need only look at the downfall of the Congress party to understand how dangerous the intoxication of power can be. They forgot the revolutionaries, and today, the youth of the country have buried the Congress," Adityanath said.

The chief minister made these remarks while inaugurating and laying the foundation stone for 107 development projects valued at over ₹311 crore in Siddharthnagar.

Coming down heavily on the Congress, Adityanath said, "Congress is moving on fully negative tracks. Why did India become a slave? There are two reasons: first, the contradictions among people, including humiliation based on caste, region, and language, which has led to the division of society. Second, there was a conspiracy by some within our own system. Those responsible for guiding the country misled society during that time."

He claimed that the very sin of dividing society, which contributed to India



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath waves the national flag during the launch of the 'Tiranga Yatra with Youth' as part of the nationwide 'Har Ghar Tiranga' campaign in Lucknow

PTI

becoming a slave, is the same mistake that Congress and the Samajwadi Party are repeating today by creating divisions along caste lines.

"What is the result of their divisive politics? Has anyone ever asked them, considering that Congress has ruled the country and the state for the longest period, what

they have done for the youth, farmers, the poor, and women during their tenure?" Adityanath questioned.

Adityanath stated that under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi, India has witnessed a transformation over the past 12 years.

"There was a time when

the world viewed India as a backward, poor, and weak nation, one that would not be able to withstand its adversaries. Today, that same India stands tall before its opponents, and the entire world is looking towards it," he said.

Crediting Modi for transforming the very India whose economy was once "devastated by Congress into the world's fourth-largest economy", Adityanath said that India, previously characterised by corruption and policy paralysis, has now emerged as a thriving startup ecosystem for its youth.

Posing a question to Rahul Gandhi and Akhilesh Yadav, the chief minister asked, "The Congress had the opportunity to govern Uttar Pradesh for a long time, and the SP has had its chief minister four times. Yet, what exactly did they do to win the support of the youth?"

Accusing the Congress of creating an identity crisis for the nation's youth, while the SP did the same for the youth of the state, Adityanath said, "When the country faces corruption, terrorism, Naxalism, extremism, and riots, and the state suffers from riots, lawlessness, and there is an environment hostile to business and investment, it is natural that the youth are the ones who are affected the most."



CM Rekha joins Hariyali Teej function in Pitampura

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta joined the Hariyali Teej celebrations at Dilli Haat in Pitampura on Sunday. She participated in festivities that included mehendi, folk songs, traditional dances, and monsoon swings, as the Delhi Tourism Department concluded its two-day Teej festival held on August 8 and 9 at Delhi Haat in both Pitampura and INA.

The festival featured competitions for women, including mehendi, bindi, rangoli, Teej Queen and Miss Teej 2026, and Best Dress Female. For children and families, attractions included a kids' zone, monsoon swings, surprise gifts, and musical chairs. The 80 handicraft and handloom stalls and 20 food stalls gave local artisans, craftspeople, and small entrepreneurs a platform to display their products and access new customers.

The Chief Minister said Hariyali Teej is not merely a festival but a celebration of faith, love, nature, and women's power. She said such festivals not only keep cultural traditions alive but also strengthen love, harmony, and a sense of togetherness in society. She said the way women celebrated at Delhi Haat, showcasing their culture through traditional attire, mehendi, folk songs, and dances, was a vibrant reflection of India's rich heritage.

She said the Delhi Government is making efforts to continuously promote cultural platforms in the capital where folk traditions and art can be passed on to the younger generation while also allowing artists and craftspeople to showcase their talent.

She extended her wishes to all women on Hariyali Teej and prayed for happiness, peace, and prosperity for everyone.

LeT commander dies after collapsing at Islamabad mosque

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

A senior commander of the Pakistan-based terrorist group Lashkar-e-Tayyiba (LeT), Qari Saeed Abdul Aziz, died after collapsing at Islamabad's Quba Mosque. He fell ill and died shortly after eating at a restaurant he did not know, and the circumstances remain unclear.

According to several reports based on local accounts and some CCTV footage, Aziz ate at an unfamiliar place on or around Saturday, August 8, 2026. He then went to the mosque, performed ablution, and collapsed either at the gate or while taking off his slippers before entering the prayer hall.

Other members tried CPR but could not revive him. He was taken to a hospital

and pronounced dead. The exact cause of death is still unknown, as there are no public autopsy results, toxicology findings, or official statements from Pakistani authorities on poisoning, natural causes, or foul play.

Aziz was not an ordinary operative in LeT. He played a central role in the group. He led the South Punjab unit of LeT's Shoaba-e-Warasa-e-Shuhada department, which provides support and monthly pensions to families of terrorists killed in Jammu and Kashmir. Intelligence sources say he had been connected to LeT chief Hafiz Saeed's network since about 1990 and was involved in recruitment. This made him an important part of the group's logistics and welfare operations for sending members into India.

The timing of Aziz's death has raised more suspicion. Just days before, a video of senior LeT-linked operative Rizwan Hanif, who is described as a PoJK deputy chief involved in recruitment and infiltration, was widely shared.

In the video, Hanif admitted that over 30 Lashkar members had been killed in the past three to four years by "unknown men" or "unknown gunmen" in cities like Peshawar, Karachi, Rawalpindi, Muzaffarabad, and Rawalakot.

Hanif accused Indian intelligence agencies of using an "unknown gunman model," though India has denied these claims in the past. This was a rare public admission of

losses from someone connected to the group.

Lashkar-e-Tayyiba, which is designated by the United Nations (UN) and was responsible for the 2008 Mumbai attack that killed 166 people, has operated in Pakistan under different names like Jamaat-ud-Dawa. In recent years, there



losses from someone connected to the group.

Lashkar-e-Tayyiba, which is designated by the United Nations (UN) and was responsible for the 2008 Mumbai attack that killed 166 people, has operated in Pakistan under different names like Jamaat-ud-Dawa. In recent years, there

FROM PAGE - 1

Other Bills scheduled are by Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal to introduce the Tribunal Reforms Bill, 2026. The Bill seeks to simplify and improve the functioning of various tribunals. It proposes greater transparency and uniformity in the appointment, selection process and tenure of tribunal chairpersons and members.

Mining Minister G Kishan Reddy will introduce the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026. The proposed changes focus on encouraging private investment and simplifying the process for exploration of critical minerals and the grant of mining leases.

Suvendu orders fresh probe into 2024 RG Kar..

The Chief Minister also directed a separate investigation into the role of some local Trinamool Congress politicians, including an MLA, into the alleged lapses during the cremation of the victim, which was reportedly done bypassing other dead bodies that were already in the queue.

"I have not forgotten ... I am doing what needs to be done and will continue to do so ... whenever I recall this day it fills my heart with pain and tears flow down the eyes," Adhikari, who had earlier suspended the then Kolkata Commissioner of Police Vineet Goyal and two other senior IPS officers for dereliction of duty, said.

The parents of the victim had earlier alleged that the victim's body, which was initially third in the queue for cremation at the Natagarh Kadamtala crematorium, was suddenly moved to the first position and her cremation was completed in undue haste. This, apart from the fact that the cremation charges were also not paid by the family members of the victim.

The three local politicians who were in question and had repeatedly been named were Nirmal Ghosh, Somnath Dey and Sanjib Mukherjee, the Chief Minister said.

Debnath, who was presently a BJP MLA, expressed satisfaction at the Chief Minister's initiative, saying, "My daughter will continue to be there with me, I inside my heart and till my alive ... my only goal is to get her justice, and I am thankful that the Chief Minister has ordered a fresh investigation." The family had earlier expressed displeasure with the way CBI conducted the investigation.

The victim's father too expressed satisfaction, saying, "The Chief Minister has been doing whatever is in his hands... he suspended three

senior IPS officers on duty then ... he took action on others too ... we are satisfied; the rest is with the judiciary."

Incidentally, all the State hospitals on Sunday observed a two-minute silence in memory of the RG Kar Medical College rape and murder case that took place exactly two years ago. A postgraduate lady doctor was raped and murdered while on duty inside the hospital premises on August 9, hitting international headlines and leading to nationwide protests.

The silence was observed from 11:00 am to 11:02 am following a directive issued by the state government. Lamps were also lit in memory of the victim, with doctors, nurses, and all medical staff taking part, along with State Health Minister Dr Sharadwath Mukherjee. Apart from this, a long march was also organised in Kolkata on the part of the citizens' forum seeking justice for the victim. The victim was allegedly raped and murdered in the night intervening August 8 and 9 of 2024, and her body was hastily disposed of following a quick autopsy conducted in the same hospital and post sundown, violating standard operating procedures.

One person, Sanjay Rai, a civic volunteer, was subsequently arrested by the Kolkata Police post which the case was transferred to the CBI following a Calcutta High Court order. In subsequent developments, the victim's family complained that the CBI failed to discharge its duties diligently and demanded fresh investigations.

AI pilot undergoes tests after drug screening

The ministry stressed that further action would depend on the outcome of the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AARB) investigation and the confirmatory laboratory report. The incident has been classified as a serious incident and is being investigated by the AARB.

Air India said it was aware that post-flight screening had been conducted on the pilots but stressed that the airline had not received the results. "We are aware that a post-flight screening test was conducted on the pilots in accordance with applicable protocols. However, the results of the test have not been shared with Air India, and we are therefore not in a position to comment on any findings," an Air India spokesperson said.

The airline also said such testing is conducted regularly as part of its regulatory compliance and is not limited to flights involved in operational incidents. "Air India undertakes regular

drug testing of crew members in compliance with civil aviation regulations, independent of any specific flight or operational incident. We will continue to cooperate with the relevant authorities as required," the airline said.

As the investigation and confirmatory testing continue, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has taken both members of the flight crew off the flying roster.

The ministry said any further action would be determined by the findings of the investigation and the final laboratory report.

The distinction between an initial screening result and a confirmed laboratory finding is significant. A non-negative or a result requiring further analysis at the screening stage does not, by itself, establish that a pilot consumed or was impaired by a prohibited substance.

The incident occurred on August 4 when Air India's Airbus A320, registration VT-EXO, operating flight AI2379 from Phuket to Delhi, experienced a sudden loss of approximately 300 feet during the cruise phase.

The aircraft stabilised following the event and continued to Delhi, where it landed safely. The flight was carrying 137 passengers, including three infants, and eight crew members - two pilots and six cabin crew members, according to the Ministry of Civil Aviation.

The sudden change in altitude resulted in injuries to some passengers and cabin crew members.

The AARB is examining the circumstances surrounding the altitude loss. Authorities have not yet announced a final cause for the incident, nor have they established any connection between the pilot's initial screening result and the aircraft's sudden loss of altitude.

Investigators are expected to examine multiple aspects of the occurrence, including the aircraft's response to the turbulence, the crew's handling of the event, weather conditions and the aircraft's technical condition.

For now, the confirmatory laboratory analysis remains pending, and the broader safety investigation is continuing.

The aviation ministry and DGCA have said they remain committed to maintaining aviation safety standards and ensuring that the incident is investigated in accordance with prescribed regulations and procedures.

Until the laboratory report and investigation are completed, no definitive conclusion can be drawn regarding the pilot's screening result or whether psychoactive substances played any role in the incident.

GRAPEVINE

Rahul’s Kiren!

The continuous logjam in the ensuing Monsoon Session of Parliament has left the Treasury benches in a quandary. The BJP-led ruling NDA is trying every bit to ensure the smooth functioning of both Houses in the last week of the scheduled session, when Home Minister Amit Shah is likely to introduce Bills and perhaps make a statement on the subject, which has led to the deadlock manoeuvred by the Congress-led opposition. The back channel engagement has started between Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi and Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju. Both share a decent rapport and have spoken over the phone in this regard a few times. Rijiju even met Rahul in person seeking cooperation. Grapevine has it that they often meet and discuss fitness, games and martial arts.

No guest accommodation?

After the reports of orders for Gymkhana Club, Jaipur Polo Grounds and similar properties to be vacated, a new similar one in the offing is likely to spoil the mood of former Parliamentarians. Conventions have it that both the serving MPs and ex-MPs were entitled to guest accommodation, which was in addition to the official bungalow or flats they were allotted. These guest accommodations were in prime North Avenues, South Avenues, Meena Bagh and adjoining areas in Lutyens Zone. Official sources said that the maximum of this accommodation was allegedly used by former MPs or their near and dear ones as permanent accommodation, and some of them have retained flats for more than three decades.

Trouble for Himachal CM

A new trouble is brewing up in the Congress-ruled Himachal Pradesh as a high-level internal rift is allegedly reported between the Government and the Bureaucracy. Recently, HP Minister Vikramaditya Singh targeted officers on the issue of non-domicile IAS and IPS officers holding crucial postings, leading to confrontation between some of the Ministers of the State and the Chief M Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu, as the postings of top level goes through the CM's lens only. A few Ministers have accused non-HP officers of prioritising personal agendas over state welfare and hence urged the CM to take firm action. Nonetheless, Deputy CM Mukesh Agnihotri has gone to the extent of warning of bureaucratic conspiracies. Grapevine has it that the matter is likely to reach the party High Command this week for a resolution on this impending crisis since it's tacit that bureaucracy plays an important role for an incumbent government to be back in power.

Mamata cavalcade attacked, BJP denies role

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

There was high political drama after a crowd of protesters on Sunday hurled sleepers, mud and water bottles at former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's motorcade when she was visiting the house of a party worker who reportedly died in police custody. Banerjee alleged the BJP and Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari's hand behind the attack.

The incident took place at Halisahar in North 24 Parganas some 50 km north of Kolkata. Even as Banerjee's car reached near the house of the deceased, a crowd surrounded it and threw water bottles, sleepers and mud even as they shouted “Chor “ (thief) and “Dakat Rani (bandit queen).”

An angry Trinamool Congress supremo immediately alighted from her car yelling at the crowd even as she alleged, “these are all BJP lumpens they have been brought from outside to heckle and harass in connivance with the police...



the Home Minister (read Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari who manages the Home portfolio too) is responsible for this me they threw big bricks at my vehicle... they targeted me and had the windows been open I could have received broken head... Such an attack I never faced in my life and all in front of the police who waited and watched with mischievous silence.

“The Home Minister is responsible for this lumpenisation of the system ... the police brass is responsible for what took place today,” Banerjee said, inviting almost

prompt reply from the Chief Minister who blamed Banerjee for trying to politicise the issue in order to remain politically afloat in the State politics.

“She still enjoys Z-Plus security that we have not withdrawn... she went there without intimidating the police moreover there was no BJP person in the crowd... no BJP flag was there... she went there to enact a political drama when the family members of the victim are saying they have full faith in the police and the administration,” Adhikari said.

State BJP president Samik

Bhattacharya condemned the Halisahar incident but rejected reports of stone-pelting. “Pelting stones or attacking politicians are not in the BJP culture... you can raise slogans, show black flags, but you cannot pelt stones; but in this case there is no report of BJP men involved in the attack.”

Earlier, Briju Keot, a TMC worker, allegedly died in police custody, leading the top TMC leader to visit his residence on Sunday. The police had on Friday arrested 48-year-old Keot, the husband of former Kanchrapara municipal councillor Jenny Sharma Keot, for his alleged involvement in financial fraud, extortion and also for possessing arms. After he was remanded to police custody, he fell ill in the lockup early on Saturday morning and was declared dead upon arrival at the Jawaharlal Nehru Memorial Hospital in Kalyani.

“This is a pre-planned murder... and we will move the Court,” both Mamata Banerjee and party MP Kalyan Banerjee said.

West Bengal heralds Har Ghar Tiranga

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The Bengal Government on Sunday organized a State wide Har Ghar Tiranga campaign to celebrate the 70th year of Independence targeting distribution of 70 lakh national flags.

The programme was earlier started by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari from his Bhawanipore constituency on Friday. During the occasion he had said that his government had issued a circular outlining the measures to be taken based on guidelines received from the Central Government.

The Government was also likely to organize a massive Tiranga Rally on Monday from the Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose statue till Gate number 1 of Birla Planetarium.

“This initiative is to inspire patriotic fervor among the people, particularly the younger generations... We expect more than



50,000 patriotic citizens will take part in the rally,” Adhikari said leading a procession at Bhawanipore and raising slogans of “Bharat Mata ki Jai (Long live India) and Vande Mataram (Hail the Motherland).”

He said, “I request all the patriotic people to take part in the procession appealing to make Prime Minister Narendra Modi's message of “Har Ghar Tiranga, Dil Se Tiranga, Pyar Se Tiranga” a grand success. The programme is likely to be observed from Sunday till August 17.

CM Shivakumar calls for Quit Vote Chori movement

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Sunday called for a “Quit Vote Chori movement” against alleged attempts at “vote theft”, urging Congress workers to focus on protecting the right to vote.

Addressing Congress workers at the KPCC office, at an event organised to mark Quit India Day, Shivakumar said the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the state made it imperative for party workers and Booth Level Agents (BLAs) to safeguard voters' rights.

“Vote theft is taking place in the country, and we need

to launch a ‘Quit Vote Chori’ movement against it,” he said. According to him, an attempt was being made to delete one crore voters through the electoral roll revision exercise.

He urged party workers to ensure that enumeration forms were duly filled and submitted. “Put aside all other work and fight against vote theft to protect the right to vote,” Shivakumar told party workers.

He also appealed to young people who have turned 18 to register as voters using Form 6, saying that without the right to vote, they would have no voice.

Recalling former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi's decision to lower the voting age to 18,



Shivakumar said the move had faced opposition from political parties at the time.

“Even though I am the Chief Minister, I am a Congress party worker first. If there are workers, there is a party; if there is a party, there is a gov-

ernment,” he said.

Drawing a parallel with Quit India movement, Shivakumar said the slogan “British Quit India” should now be replaced with ‘Dictatorial Mindset Quit Power’.

“Swaraj is our birthright” should today be understood as “Protest is our birthright”, he said, recalling the contributions of Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and Maulana Abul Kalam Azad to the freedom movement.

Shivakumar said the Constitution was the country's “Bible, Quran and Bhagavad Gita” and asserted that the Congress party would “never bow, bend or back down”.

He claimed that attempts have been made to eliminate the Congress and the Congress family from the country, but asserted that the party continued to remain strong.

“Our target is 2028 (assembly polls) and 2029 (Lok

Sabha polls). Some are speaking about creating a ‘Congress-free’ India. The strength of Congress is the strength of the country; the history of Congress is the history of the country.”

On the proposed expansion of Congress infrastructure, Shivakumar said the party has decided to construct 100 offices across Karnataka in connection with the centenary celebrations of the Belagavi session where Mahatma Gandhi became Congress president.

He said land had been acquired in every taluk and that Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge would soon visit the state for foundation-laying programmes.

दिल्ली सरकार

Delhi Tourism

Delhi: The Capital of Spirituality, Heritage & Experiences

JOIN US TO CELEBRATE

the timeless legacy of India's capital through its sacred traditions, iconic heritage and vibrant cultural diversity

Delhi Tourism's Official YouTube Channel

@DelhiTourismdelhigovt

OR

Scan the QR Code

Guided by the vision of ‘Virasat Bhi, Vikas Bhi’, efforts ranging from the repatriation of antiquities to strengthening spiritual and pilgrimage infrastructure are reconnecting people with India's timeless traditions.

Narendra Modi
Prime Minister

Rekha Gupta
Chief Minister, Delhi

Preserving Heritage • Promoting Culture • Inspiring the World

Delhi Tourism & Transportation Development Corporation (DTDC), Government of NCT of Delhi

DIP/Shabdarth/Display/065/26-27

Operation Sindoor showed India’s strength: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Operation Sindoor demonstrated the unmatched valour of our defence forces who sent a global message that India will go to any extent to ensure the safety of its citizens while protecting the sindoor worn by our women, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Sunday.

Making this assertion while addressing the ‘Sindoor Maharaktadan Yatra’ blood donation camp at Base Hospital, Delhi Cantonment, he commended the Indian forces for eliminating terrorists and their handlers based in Pakistan and ensuring that those who dared to cast an evil eye on India faced dire

consequences. Drawing a parallel with Sindoor Maharaktadan Yatra, Rajnath Singh asserted that while Operation Sindoor showcased courage, the mega blood donation camp represents compassion.

Approximately 1,000 wrestlers and athletes from Maharashtra were among the donors who participated in the camp, demonstrating the spirit of selfless service and solidarity with the Defence Forces.

Expressing gratitude to the donors, the defence minister expressed confidence that the blood donated today would serve as a credible reserve for needy soldiers and their families in the future. He described blood donation as jivandan and



mahadan and stressing that despite remarkable advances in science and medicine, no artificial substitute for human blood has yet been developed. Since blood can only be produced by the human body and donated by one person

to another, Rajnath Singh said, blood donation remains one of the noblest forms of charity.

He underlined that every blood donor and recipient is, in their own way, serving the nation. He urged the

people, particularly the youth, to make blood donation a culture.

Calling upon the youth to prioritise fitness, the defence minister emphasised that a healthy and fit individual becomes a greater asset to society and is better equipped to undertake noble causes such as blood donation.

Highlighting Maharashtra’s enduring tradition of valour and compassion, Rajnath Singh said that the legacy of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj continues to inspire generations.

He emphasised that the true purpose of physical strength lies in protecting others and safeguarding the nation, adding that the contribution of the athletes and

wrestlers from the land of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj would be remembered as a noble service to the nation.

The event was attended by Deputy Chief Minister of Maharashtra Eknath Shinde; Minister of State for Ayush (Independent Charge) Pratap Rao Jadhav; Minister of Industries, Government of Maharashtra Uday Ravindra Samant; Member of Parliament Dr Srikant Lata Eknath Shinde; Chief of the Army Staff General Dhiraj Seth; DG Armed Forces Medical Services (AFMS) Surgeon Vice Admiral Arti Sarin; Adjutant General Lt General VPS Kaushik; Commandant, Base Hospital, Delhi Cantonment Major General Vishal Chaudhary and other senior military and civil dignitaries.

Nation Focus



Specialist Diving and Explosive Ordnance Disposal teams of the Indian Navy and the US Navy pose for a group photo in front of a naval helicopter at the Southern Naval Command base in Kochi, Kerala PTI

INDIA, US NAVIES TO HOLD 8TH EOD EXERCISE IN KOCHI FROM AUG 10-14

An exercise between the navies of India and the US, which aims to enhance interoperability and strengthen professional cooperation between specialist diving and Explosive Ordnance Disposal (EOD) teams of the two sides, is set to be held in Kochi, from August 10-14, officials said on Sunday. The Indian Navy and US Navy have been conducting joint salvage and EOD exercises since 2005.

“The Indian Navy-US Navy explosive ordnance disposal (EOD) exercise is scheduled to be conducted at Southern Naval Command, Kochi, from August 10-14,” a spokesperson of the Indian Navy said.

The bilateral exercise aims to enhance interoperability and strengthen professional cooperation between the specialist diving and EOD teams of the two navies, the official said. (PNS)



3.3-MAGNITUDE EARTHQUAKE JOLTS RAPAR IN KUTCH

A mild earthquake measuring 3.3 on the Richter scale shook Rapar and adjoining areas of Kutch on Sunday afternoon, triggering brief concern among residents.

According to the Seismology Department, the tremor was recorded at around 1.34 pm, with its epicentre located approximately 15 km from Rapar.

The tremor was accompanied by a loud rumbling sound, following which residents in areas near the epicentre reportedly stepped outside their homes as a precaution. There were, however, no reports of casualties or damage to property at the time of reporting.

Kutch falls within a very high-risk seismic zone and experiences tremors from time to time. (PNS)

PM remembers quit India Movement on 84th anniversary



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday remembered those who participated in the historic Quit India Movement, and said their courage will always remain an inspiration for every Indian. The Quit India Movement was launched under the leadership of Mahatma Gandhi on August 9, 1942 and gave a decisive impetus to India’s quest for independence.

“Remembering all those

who participated in the historic Quit India Movement. Their courage will always remain an inspiration for every Indian,” Modi said in a post on social media..

The prime minister said the clarion call of Quit India infused new energy in the freedom struggle and reflected the unwavering determination of people to break free from colonial rule.

August 9, 2026, marks the 84th anniversary of the Quit India Movement, one of the defining milestones in the nation’s freedom struggle.

India to lead next biotech, AI-driven industrial revolution: Jitendra Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India will be an essential player in the next industrial revolution, which will be biotechnology and AI-driven, unlike the last industrial revolution, which was IT-driven and India was late in becoming a part of that, Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Science & Technology and Earth Sciences Jitendra Singh, said on Sunday.

Speaking at a media conclave, he said India is now among the first few countries in the world to have a dedicated Biotechnology policy, that is BIOE3. We also have a National Quantum Mission, India AI Mission and have made rapid advances in Space and other frontier areas.

He said India’s space economy, which was earlier almost negligible, has grown to around \$9 billion and is projected to reach \$40–45



billion within the next eight to nine years.

The minister participated in an interaction with the media at the conclave, attended by technology developers, industry leaders and other stakeholders.

The discussion focused on India’s emergence as a global manufacturing and technology hub, the rapid

pace of technological change, innovation, private-sector participation and the opportunities emerging in frontier sectors. The Minister also congratulated the winners of the Digital Appliance Awards.

He said India’s technological journey has undergone a significant transformation, with the country now operating against global benchmarks in several areas. Referring to India’s progress in space, he cited the Chandrayaan mission’s detection of evidence of water molecules on the Moon as an example of the country contributing to global scientific knowledge.

He said India had never lacked human talent or scientific capability, but what was required was an enabling policy environment that could translate these capabilities into outcomes.

ED files chargesheets in two money laundering cases linked to RAAG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) announced on Sunday that it had filed chargesheets in two distinct money-laundering cases involving companies and former executives associated with the Reliance Anil Ambani Group (RAAG).

In the first case, the ED filed a prosecution complaint on Saturday in a special Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) court in Dwarka against Reliance Infrastructure Limited, former Reliance Group executive Sateesh Seth, who is 70, and others.

The ED arrested Seth in June, and he is still in judicial custody. He left the Reliance Group in 2025. In the second case, the ED filed a supplementary chargesheet on Saturday in a special court at Rouse Avenue related to Reliance Communications Limited (RCOM). The main chargesheet was filed in March.

The agency said that RCOM, Reliance Telecom Limited (RTL), former RAAG executives Seth, Gautam Doshi, Amitabh Jhunjhunwala, and others are named as accused in this prosecution complaint under the PMLA.

The ED arrested Doshi in June and Seth in July. Both remain in judicial custody. Doshi left the RAAG in 2020. The chargesheet in the Reliance Infrastructure case is based on a February FIR from the Mumbai Police Economic Offences Wing (EOW). The FIR says that shell companies were created and operated using forged documents and bank accounts to move money and



send funds overseas through fake invoices for overpriced diamond exports.

The ED said its investigation found an “organised scheme” to “divert” public funds from four toll-road projects awarded by the NHAI: Trichy-Karur (NH-67), Trichy-Dindigul (NH-45), Salem-Ulundurpet (NH-68), and Jaipur-Reengus (NH-11). The projects were funded by NHAI grants and loans from banks and financial institutions.

“About ₹187 crore was siphoned during September-October 2010 through sham, post-facto or back-dated arrangements for fictitious sub-contracting work,” the agency has alleged.

The agency said that funds were moved from Reliance Infrastructure, its project-specific special purpose vehicles, or EPC contractors to construction contractors, and then to shell companies not involved in road construction. “Documents were later created to make the transfers look like real project expenses, while the money was moved through shell companies and diamond traders,” the ED said. The agency also said it has

attached immovable assets and equity shares of Reliance Power Limited, held by Reliance Infrastructure, as well as land in the name of Ksheeraabd Constructions worth ₹187 crore. “Further investigation with respect to the role of other individuals is underway,” it has added.

The supplementary chargesheet is based on several CBI FIRs that claim RCOM, RTL, and Reliance Infratel Limited diverted both fund-based and non-fund-based credit facilities. The investigation found that new credit was often used to repay, rotate, and extend earlier domestic and foreign debts, instead of being used for its approved purposes.

“Funds were layered through group companies, purpose-built conduit entities, multiple bank accounts, and liquid mutual funds; used to pay off earlier External Commercial Borrowings and Foreign Currency Convertible Bonds (FCCB); and shown as legitimate business expenses or income,” the agency alleged. It also said that loan proceeds were “diverted” to group companies like Reliance Infrastructure Limited and Reliance Capital Limited, siphoned off to buy personal assets for the promoters outside India, and used to inflate RCOM’s profits artificially.

The ED estimates the proceeds of crime in this case at ₹40,185 crore and has attached assets worth ₹8,078 crore. The agency has asked for these assets to be confiscated from the Anil Ambani Group in its chargesheet. Former RAAG executives named in the case could not be reached for comment.

NIA arrests key conspirator in Malappuram illegal explosives case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has arrested another key suspect in the Malappuram illegal explosives case, raising the total number of arrests to ten. On Saturday, Haris TA was taken into custody in Manjeri, Malappuram district, Kerala. Authorities say he was a main conspirator and played a major role in illegally obtaining the explosives.

Haris TA’s arrest is part of the NIA’s ongoing investigation into a planned interstate effort to obtain, move, and store large amounts of illegal explosives. The case, registered as RC-01/2026/NIA/KOC, began when Kerala Police found a lorry (KL 10 BF 8395) parked at Farha Hollow Bricks Company on Chennad-Thalappara Road, Malappuram, on February 7, 2026.

When the Kerala police officers searched the vehicle, they found 89,600 explosive sticks and 10,500 shock tubes (NONEL). Three people linked to the shipment were arrested at the scene. None of them had valid licenses or permits to transport or possess the explosives, which made the operation illegal under the Explosives Act and



related laws. Given the seriousness and possible national security risks, the NIA re-registered the case and took charge of the investigation. Since then, the agency has searched 19 locations in three states, found important evidence, and identified more suspects involved in the conspiracy. Haris TA on Saturday followed closely on the heels of another significant development: on August 7, the NIA arrested three more suspects from Vijayapura, Karnataka, Mantagoud Biradar, Papagoud Bheeramaya Choudri, and Prakash Gauda Biradar, all from Vijayapura district.

With Haris TA in custody, the total number of arrests in the case is now ten. Investigators believe the seized explosives were part of a broader network involved

in illegal procurement and distribution. Recovery of over 10,000 shock tubes has raised serious concerns about the possible end-use of the material and the sophistication of the supply chain that enabled it to reach Malappuram undetected until the February interception.

Throughout the probe, the NIA has focused on tracing the origin of the explosives, the financing of the operation, and the roles played by various individuals at different stages of procurement, storage and transportation, sources said.

By conducting searches in several states, the NIA has mapped out how far the conspiracy spread and found important leads. Officials said that Mantagoud Biradar, Papagoud Bheeramaya Choudri, and Prakash Gauda

Biradar had licenses to deal with explosives in some cases. However, they still broke the law by selling and moving the seized materials. This highlights the challenges of the clandestine explosives trade, which poses serious risks to public safety and national security.

Agencies continue to stress the importance of strict compliance with licensing norms for manufacturing, transporting, and storing explosives. The lack of valid permits in this case underscores the deliberate nature of the violation. As the investigation progresses, the NIA is expected to file additional chargesheets and continue efforts to dismantle the network behind the illegal consignment.

The arrest of Haris TA, named as a main conspirator in getting the explosives, along with the earlier arrests of Mantagoud Biradar, Papagoud Bheeramaya Choudri, and Prakash Gauda Biradar, is an important step in uncovering the whole plot. “With searches in several states and more suspects in custody, the agency is working to make sure everyone involved in the illegal explosives trade is held accountable”, the sources added.

AIIMS Delhi performs second dual kidney transplant from 70-year-old donor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The country’s premier institute, AIIMS-Delhi, has performed its second dual kidney transplant using organs from a marginal donor, a 70-year-old woman who was declared brain dead, for a single recipient, doctors said.

The surgery underscores efforts to expand the deceased-donor pool and provide kidney transplantation to more patients with end-stage kidney disease.

The successful transplant was performed on July 28 by the Department of Surgical Disciplines in collaboration with the departments of Nephrology, Anaesthesia,

Transplant Immunology and the Organ Retrieval Banking Organisation (ORBO), AIIMS, Delhi.

The donor, a septuagenarian woman from Command Hospital, Chandimandir, Chandigarh, was considered a marginal donor due to her advanced age.

Kidneys from marginal donors, also called expanded criteria donors, come from individuals with higher medical risks or those who are over 60 years of age.

“In view of the advanced age and marginal donor characteristics, both kidneys were utilised for transplantation in a single recipient as a carefully planned strategy to maximise the use of available

donor organs,” Dr Asuri Krishna, professor in the department of Surgery at AIIMS-Delhi, said.

The kidneys were transported from Chandigarh to Delhi by an Army helicopter, enabling their rapid transfer. Despite a cold ischaemia time of around 12 hours, both kidneys started functioning immediately after transplantation, Dr Krishna said.

The recipient, a 56-year-old woman, underwent implantation of both kidneys on the right side. She had an uneventful recovery and was discharged after 10 days with normal kidney function, according to the doctors.

The organ retrieval and transplantation were facilitat-



ed by coordinated efforts involving the Army Research and Referral Hospital, Delhi, and various teams at AIIMS. AIIMS Director Dr Nikhil

Tandon provided support and guidance for the procedure, while Balram, transplant coordinator at ORBO, played a key role in coordi-

nating the logistics, communication, organ retrieval and transportation, Dr Krishna said. The transplant surgery was led by Dr Krishna, along

with Dr Sushant, Dr Aditya Bakshi, Dr Brijesh Kumar Singh and Dr Mohit Sangade of the Department of Surgical Disciplines.

The nephrology team was involved in recipient assessment, perioperative management and post-transplant care.

Dual kidney transplantation from carefully selected marginal donors is a strategy to increase utilisation of deceased-donor organs. In selected cases, both kidneys from a donor may be transplanted into a single recipient to provide adequate renal function and utilise organs that might otherwise be declined because of donor age or other margin-

al characteristics, Dr Krishna said. The latest procedure was AIIMS-Delhi’s second such dual kidney transplant from a marginal donor and underscores efforts to expand the deceased-donor pool and provide kidney transplantation to more patients with end-stage kidney disease, he said.

“The immediate functioning of both kidneys despite around 12 hours of cold ischaemia and the recipient’s discharge with normal kidney function after 10 days marked an encouraging early outcome,” he said. Cold ischemia is the preservation phase of a donor organ to slow metabolism before transplantation.

Har Ghar Tiranga campaign: PM urges enthusiastic participation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday urged people to enthusiastically participate in the 'Har Ghar Tiranga' campaign and said India's national flag is the country's pride and a constant source of inspiration to always give the best for the nation.

The 'Har Ghar Tiranga' campaign, which began in 2022 under 'Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav', has become an annual national tradition, with crores of citizens voluntarily hoisting the national flag every Independence Day. "Our Tricolour is our pride and a constant source of



Participants carry a national tricolour during the 'Tiranga Yatra' organised by the Nagpur Municipal Corporation (NMC) as part of the nationwide 'Har Ghar Tiranga' campaign in Nagpur, Maharashtra on Sunday

PTI

inspiration to always give our best for the nation. Let us participate enthusiastically in the #HarGharTiranga

movement and renew our collective resolve to contribute towards building a Viksit Bharat," Modi said in a

post on social media. The prime minister said he was glad that this year's efforts are dedicated to national song 'Vande Mataram' and that too at a time when the nation is marking its 150th anniversary.

The 2026 edition of the 'Har Ghar Tiranga' campaign was launched on August 6 and will be observed across the country from August 9 to 17.

The campaign, which has evolved into one of India's largest public participation movements, calls upon citizens to proudly hoist the national flag and participate in a wide range of activities celebrating the spirit of patriotism and national unity.

Tamil Nadu Police arrest 837 in 48-hour cybercrime crackdown

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

In a major crackdown on cybercrime networks, the Tamil Nadu police arrested 837 people during a 48-hour Statewide drive targeting mule bank account holders, officials said on Sunday.

The special operation, conducted on August 6 and 7, targeted individuals linked to 9,804 complaints registered on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, involving fraudulent transactions totalling ₹545.27 crore.

According to a police statement, those arrested were linked to 601 existing FIRs registered in connection with cybercrime cases.



Police also registered 157 new FIRs across the state to curb the misuse and operation of mule bank accounts. Police explained that mule accounts are bank accounts used by cybercriminals to receive, transfer, layer or withdraw illicit funds.

Individuals who share their account details for

commissions facilitate such fraudulent transactions, they said. During the operation, police seized 204 mobile phones, 185 SIM cards, four laptops/desktops, a storage device, 114 bank passbooks, 29 cheque books, 73 ATM/debit cards, a credit card, two other electronic devices and ₹1.02 lakh in cash.

Nine injured in steel plant blast in Jharkhand's Ramgarh: Official

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ramgarh (Jharkhand)

At least nine workers were injured following an explosion in a furnace chamber at a private steel plant in Jharkhand's Ramgarh district on Sunday, an official said.

The incident occurred at Murpa village under Kuju outpost limits on Sunday afternoon, the official said.

Chief Factory Inspector Manish Sinha said two critically injured workers have been referred to a private hospital in Ranchi.

"Workers sustained burn injuries after hot metal splashed following an explosion in the furnace chamber of the plant. Factory inspector in Hazaribag has been directed to inquire into the issue and submit details report at the earliest," he said.



Bharat is one and will always remain one: VP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Sri Vijaya Puram

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Sunday said "Bharat is one and will always remain one" as he launched the Har Ghar Tiranga Abhiyaan from the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, underlining the spirit of national unity, patriotism and sacrifice associated with the historic archipelago.

Addressing the gathering at the DBRAIT Auditorium here, Radhakrishnan recalled the words of Tamil nationalist poet Subramania Bharati, saying, "My head will never bow; my head will bow only for the national flag of Mother Bharat."

He said the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign carries forward this spirit by bringing every citizen together under the national

the dreaded "Kalapani" punishment.

Referring to the Cellular Jail, he said the national memorial remains an eternal reminder of the extraordinary courage of freedom fighters, including Veer Vinayak Damodar Savarkar, Batukeshwar Dutt and Sachindra Nath Sanyal.

The Vice President also recalled Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose's historic hoisting of the Tricolour at Sri Vijaya Puram on December 30, 1943, describing the event as a powerful symbol of India's resolve for independence.

Radhakrishnan also hoisted the National Flag at Flag Point, Sri Vijaya Puram, under the #HarGharTiranga Abhiyaan. Radhakrishnan highlighted the unique character of the Andaman and



Vice President CP Radhakrishnan arrives Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose Island in Andaman and Nicobar Islands

PTI

flag, one motherland and one common destiny.

The programme was attended by Lieutenant Governor of Andaman and Nicobar Islands Admiral DK Joshi (Retd), Chief Secretary Chanchal Yadav, Chairperson of the Sri Vijaya Puram Municipal Council M Vasanta and Adhyaksh, Zilla Parishad, South Andaman, P Umar, among other dignitaries.

Radhakrishnan said the launch from the Andaman and Nicobar Islands was deeply significant as it coincided with Quit India Movement Day, commemorating Mahatma Gandhi's call of "Do or Die" on August 8, 1942.

He described the islands as a sacred land inseparably linked with India's freedom struggle and paid tribute to the thousands of freedom fighters who endured imprisonment, forced labour and inhuman treatment under

Nicobar Islands as "Mini India", with people from different parts of the country living together across its 31 inhabited islands. He said the Union Territory exemplifies "unity in diversity" and the spirit of "Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat".

He also highlighted the presence of six tribal communities, including five Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups, and appreciated efforts towards education, healthcare, skill development and livelihood while preserving their cultural identity.

Referring to development initiatives, Radhakrishnan mentioned improved connectivity, healthcare and education infrastructure, including the submarine optical fibre cable, the new integrated terminal building at Veer Savarkar International Airport, ANIIMS and Government Law College.

Pralhad Joshi meets officials to discuss strengthening NTA, streamlining exams

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi on Sunday held a meeting with senior officials, including the education secretary, to discuss matters related to the National Testing Agency (NTA).

The meeting focused on measures to strengthen institutional mechanisms, streamline examination processes and make the agency



more responsive to students. "Convened a meeting with the Secretary and senior officials of @EduMinOfIndia on matters concerning the National Testing Agency (NTA).

"Deliberated on key matters requiring attention and the steps ahead to further strengthen institutional mechanisms, streamline processes and ensure greater responsiveness to students," Joshi said in a post on social media. "Our

focus remains on building a robust, transparent and credible examination ecosystem that serves the aspirations of every student," he said.

Joshi was appointed as education minister on July 26 after Dharmendra Pradhan resigned from the post. Pradhan resigned from his post following the Cockroach Janta Party-led student protests across the country, demanding his ouster over the NEET paper leak controversy.

India aims to emerge as leading exporter of dairy products: Rajiv Ranjan Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister for Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying Rajiv Ranjan Singh has said the Government of India is committed to positioning India among the world's leading exporters of milk and dairy products, building on the country's success in the fisheries sector.

Inaugurating the 3rd National Sustainable Agriculture Summit & Awards 2026 in the national capital, the Union Minister said the government's sustained focus on strengthening dairy and fisheries is in line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat and Viksit Bharat 2047, where a robust agricultural economy and diversified rural enterprises play a central role in improving farmers' incomes and ensuring long-term rural prosperity.

The Summit was organised by Sustainability Matters, IndiAgri and Action for Change, Transformation

& Innovation (ACTION), bringing together policymakers, senior government officials, industry leaders, scientists, researchers and farmers to deliberate on the future of sustainable agriculture and rural development.

Singh said the Government has undertaken a series of initiatives to strengthen dairying and fisheries as key drivers of rural prosperity, farmer income and exports. He reiterated that expanding rural enterprises through these sectors remains a national priority and that creating a separate Ministry for Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying in 2019 ensured focused policy attention and greater investment in these high-potential sectors.

"India today is the world's largest producer of milk and the second-largest producer of fish. Our objective is not only to increase production but also to establish India among the leading exporters of milk and dairy products, just as we have strengthened our position in fisheries exports. Scientific interven-



NNDDB Chairman Dr Muneesh Shah, Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh, Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Jha inaugurating the summit. Also seen in the photo is IRFC CMD Manoj Kumar Dubey

PIONEER PHOTO

tions, infrastructure development, disease control programmes and value-chain investments are helping transform these sectors into engines of rural growth," the Minister said.

He noted that India's milk production has reached nearly 248 million tonnes, while inland fisheries production has grown by more than 105 per cent, with the fisheries sector recording overall growth of nearly 147 per cent. He highlighted flagship initiatives such as the

Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana, Fisheries and Aquaculture Infrastructure Development Fund, and the Livestock Health and Disease Control Programme, alongside technologies including sex-sorted semen and IVF that are improving livestock productivity and enhancing farmers' incomes.

The Minister also underlined the importance of biogas plants in generating additional rural income through the productive use

of agricultural and animal waste, while contributing to environmental sustainability. He added that India's vaccination drive against Foot and Mouth Disease (FMD) and engagement with the World Organisation for Animal Health (WOAH) are helping create internationally recognised disease-free zones, opening new opportunities for exports of livestock and dairy products. These remarks are consistent with the Government's broader policy direction for the sector.

Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Kumar Jha said that while dairy and fisheries had traditionally been considered part of agriculture, it was only after 2019 that the two sectors received a decisive policy push through focused institutional support.

He said this shift has enabled states such as Bihar to build integrated agricultural models encompassing crop farming, horticulture, dairy and fisheries, thereby strengthening rural livelihoods and expanding income opportunities for

farmers. Dr Navneet Anand, Executive Director, Sustainability Matters, said, "India's agricultural transformation depends on strengthening every pillar of the rural economy.

Dairy, fisheries, livestock, sustainable farming and innovation must progress together if we are to achieve higher farmer incomes, food security and long-term sustainability. This Summit serves as a platform to bring together government, industry, academia and farmers to collectively shape that future."

Among the distinguished dignitaries present was Dr Meenesh C Shah, Chairman, National Dairy Development Board (NDDB); Manoj Kumar Dubey, Chairman, Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC); Dr Rajendra Prasad, GM, SIDBI, along with senior policymakers, industry leaders, scientists and stakeholders from across the agriculture value chain.

The Summit was supported by IRFC, SIDBI, NABARD, KRIBHCO, HURL, Sira Seeds, Comfed and Omfed.

Trainer aircraft veers off runway during training exercise in Maharashtra's Baramati

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Pune

A trainer aircraft operated by private aviation academy Carver Aviation veered off the runway during a training exercise at the Baramati airfield in Maharashtra's Pune district on Sunday, police said. No injuries were reported.

The incident took place at around 12.30 pm and involved an aircraft carrying a pilot and a cadet, according to police officials.

Officials said the aircraft was conducting a circuit-and-landing emergency training exercise when it was unable to stop within the designated portion of the runway.

The aircraft travelled beyond the runway threshold before moving onto the grassy area beside the paved surface.

As part of the exercise, the aircraft first positioned itself at the threshold of Runway 29 and carried out a rejected take-off. It was subsequently moved to the

threshold of Runway 11, where another rejected take-off was performed.

During the exercise, the aircraft again failed to come to a complete stop on the runway and continued beyond the runway end. It then moved off the extended paved surface towards the right side beyond the Runway 29 threshold.

Police said the aircraft travelled approximately 20 feet beyond the end of the runway before entering the

grass. There were no reported casualties or injuries.

The incident comes months after another aviation accident at the same airstrip. On January 28, a private charter aircraft carrying then Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Ajit Pawar and four other people crashed near the Baramati airfield. All five people on board were killed.

In another incident on May 13, a trainer aircraft operated by a different private aviation company



made a crash landing near the Baramati airstrip after reportedly developing a

technical problem. No casualties were reported in that incident either.

Amit Shah honours Puducherry Police, presents President's Colour for exemplary service to nation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Puducherry

Union Home Minister Amit Shah presented the President's Colour to Puducherry Police on Sunday and praised the force for its commitment and dedication in ensuring the country's internal security.

Referring to the Government doing away with British-era criminal laws, including the Indian Penal Code (IPC), Shah said its replacement, the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) was enacted with the intention of ensuring justice to citizens.

In his address after presenting the President's Colour to the Union Territory's police force, he said the new criminal laws are based on the "three pillars of technology, timeline and trust."

the highest honour given to a military unit or police force of a State or union territory. Past recipients of the honour include the Indian Navy, Indian Coast Guard and various State police departments.

President Droupadi Murmu had announced on May 8 the conferment of the honour on Puducherry police in recognition of its "exceptional service, discipline and distinguished achievements".

Underlining the Centre's commitment to the UT's growth, Shah said Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision over the last 12 years has been to strengthen it.

To make Puducherry strong, several development initiatives, including investments to the tune of ₹39,000 crore in the last nine years and road expansion activities worth thousands of crores of rupees, have



Union Home Minister Amit Shah presents the prestigious 'President's Colour' (Nishaan) to the Puducherry Police at the Puducherry Armed Police Ground in Gorimedu, Puducherry. Puducherry Director General of Police (DGP) Shalini Singh and officer personnel are present

PTI

been taken up, he said.

While the UT received about ₹3,500 crore in Central fund allocation between 1950

and 2014, the NDA Government provided Rs 13,762 crore during the 2014-26 period to it, he added.

Various Government initiatives, including Lakhpati Didi, Ujjwala and PM Awas schemes, direct benefit trans-

fer and construction of toilets have benefited about seven lakh citizens in Puducherry, he said.

"Puducherry police has received the Nishaan (President's Colour). In this golden hour, let me assure on PM Modi's behalf, the Government is committed to the union territory's development," Shah underlined.

Shah praised the UT police force for its dedication and commitment to maintaining law and order in Puducherry, which is geographically spread across different states in the south- Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh (Yanam) and Kerala (Mahe). It has been playing a crucial role in the area of internal security for years, he added.

"The President's flag is the most honourable moment for any police force. Puducherry police may number around 5,000 but

has been maintaining the UT's safety and its internal security. You don't do it due to any file or order but due to your sense of commitment and dedication."

"During the challenging COVID-19 scenario, I used to review the situation in States and UTs, and the Puducherry police went the extra mile to serve people — the women and children," he said.

He described the moment in which Puducherry police received the President's Colour as a "golden episode" in its history.

He lauded the force on behalf of President Murmu and PM Modi.

Earlier, the HM presented the President's Colour to the force's Ensign Officer at an official event held at the Puducherry Armed Police Ground in neighbouring Gorimedu. Shah was accompanied by DGP Shalini Singh.

Lieutenant Governor K Kailashnathan, Chief Minister N Rangasamy and Home Minister A Namassivayam, among others, were present.

Heaping praises on Puducherry and its people, Shah said that despite being under French rule for about 230 years, it has "maintained its Indianness and spiritual energy". He credited Aurobindo and the Mother for this spiritual energy, which he said has now spread across the country. "Puducherry is the symbol of south Indian culture and spirituality," he said. Freedom fighter and national poet Subramanya Bharathi's long residence in Puducherry spread the patriotic fervour "to the Himalayas". Puducherry police has joined a list of police forces across the country who have been bestowed with the President's Colour, he added.



Editor's
TAKE

Women’s quota, held hostage to delimitation

The women's reservation law, passed three ago is yet to be implemented as it remains trapped in a political maze linking census, delimitation and federal interests

Three years ago, Parliament did something it rarely does: agree unanimously. The Rajya Sabha passed the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, the Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, 2023, by 214 votes to none, promising a third of all seats in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies to women, with a further third of that share reserved for Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe women. Six previous attempts had failed since 1996; this one finally succeeded.

What has still not happened, even now, is a single woman entering a legislature under its provisions – because the Act made its own arrival conditional on events outside its control. Article 334A ties the reservation's commencement to a fresh delimitation exercise, and delimitation cannot proceed without a fresh census. India's census, due in 2021, remains uncompleted five years on. No census, no delimitation; no delimitation, no quota.

The government's stated reasoning – that redrawing constituencies on decades-old population data would be unfair to faster-growing states – is defensible in principle. In practice, it has left a landmark law in permanent suspension. In April, the government tried to force the issue with a package deal. The Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill would use 2011 census figures to redraw constituencies at once, expand the Lok Sabha toward 850 seats – about 273 of them reserved for women – and deliver the quota by 2029. It fell 54 votes short of the two-thirds majority required, 298 for and 230 against, and the government withdrew the companion Delimitation and Union Territories bills alongside it. The Monsoon Session, due to end August 13, has kept both off the agenda.

The Opposition's objection was never to reservation itself; several parties have also pressed for an explicit OBC sub-quota within it. But their core case is that the 2023 Act never needed a national head-count to hand women a third of the seats that already exist; only a fresh redrawing of constituency boundaries requires fresh population data.

Bundling the two, Congress and its allies argue, was designed to smuggle a contentious redistribution – one that would shift seats away from southern and north-eastern states, which slowed population growth fastest, toward the more populous north – inside a bill no party could be seen opposing.

That the government needed a mid-course rewrite of its own 2023 law to attempt this only strengthens that suspicion. The way forward needs no new drafting genius, only the will to separate two questions that were never one. Implement the 33 per cent quota now, on the map as it stands, rotating reserved seats each term as the law already allows. Negotiate delimitation on its own track, with the interstate guarantees the South is asking for settled before the exercise begins, not promised after. Three years of consensus on paper deserve better than a fourth year of deadlock in practice.



BHOPIDNER SINGH

History offers a sobering reminder that even the world's most powerful militaries are not immune to depleted arsenals. The United States has repeatedly confronted the consequences of munitions shortages - from the opening months of the Korean War, when inadequate stockpiles and strained logistics forced commanders to ration artillery fire, to the prolonged campaigns in Vietnam and Afghanistan, where years of sustained operations exposed weaknesses in procurement, production capacity, and supply chains.

Each time, Washington recovered by mobilising its industrial base, expanding defence production, strengthening logistics, and rebuilding strategic reserves. Yet history appears to be echoing once again. Years of military assistance to Ukraine, combined with the demands of a prolonged conflict with Iran that has lasted far beyond initial expectations, have renewed concerns over the resilience of U.S. munitions inventories. The issue is not whether America possesses the world's most advanced weapons. That it does. But whether it can manufacture, replenish, and sustain them at the pace demanded by modern high-intensity warfare.

The first visible indication of mounting pressure came with the administration's request for emergency funding from Congress (reportedly around \$87 billion) to support military operations and 'rapidly replenish equipment and munitions'. Such a request is more than a budgetary measure; it reflects a strategic reality: even the United States can find its military capabilities constrained when operational demand outpaces industrial capacity.

The lesson from Korea remains relevant. In 1950, Washington expected a short campaign that many believed would end by Christmas. Instead, Chinese intervention transformed a limited 'police action' into a three-year war of attrition, forcing the United States to rapidly expand its defence industrial base. The conflict demonstrated a recurring truth of warfare i.e., political timelines rarely match military realities, and ammunition stocks can be exhausted long before strategic objectives are achieved.

A similar challenge appears to have emerged during the Iran conflict. Operation Epic Fury was conceived as a rapid campaign aimed at achieving decisive military objectives. Instead, the conflict has continued for months, creating sustained demand for precision-guided munitions, air-defence interceptors, and long-range strike weapons. The resulting pressure on inventories

America’s arsenal under strain

Strategic autonomy ultimately rests not just on acquiring advanced weapons, but on having the industrial capacity and diversified supply chains to keep them operational when a war lasts longer than expected.



THE CREDIBILITY OF DEFENCE PARTNERSHIPS IS THEREFORE MEASURED NOT ONLY BY CONTRACTS SIGNED DURING PEACETIME, BUT BY THE RELIABILITY OF SUPPLY CHAINS DURING WARTIME. ALLIES DO NOT MERELY PURCHASE WEAPONS; THEY INVEST IN THE PROMISE THAT THOSE WEAPONS WILL REMAIN OPERATIONAL WHEN NATIONAL SECURITY IS AT STAKE

The writer, a military veteran, is a former Lt Governor of Andaman & Nicobar Islands and Puducherry

has intensified calls for additional funding and accelerated production.

Defence analysts have highlighted the strain on U.S. missile stocks. The Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS) has estimated significant reductions in inventories of systems such as Patriot interceptors and Terminal High Altitude Area Defense (THAAD) missiles after sustained operational use. Such assessments have fueled concerns about whether Washington can maintain adequate reserves for future contingencies while meeting current commitments. They have also provided adversaries an opportunity to portray reported shortages as evidence of declining American military strength.

The debate has taken on a political dimension in Washington as well. Reports that President Donald Trump confronted Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth over possible weapons shortages intensified scrutiny of U.S. preparedness. The President strongly rejected such reporting, describing it as 'treasonous' and promising severe action against those responsible for leaks. Yet the controversy highlights a deeper issue - precise information about U.S. weapons inventories remains classified, and increased restrictions on Pentagon information have made independent assessments more difficult. Secrecy may protect operational details, but it can also amplify uncertainty.

If concerns over U.S. military preparedness and defence manufacturing capacity prove accurate, the implications extend well beyond America's current conflicts. The question is not simply whether Washington can sustain ongoing operations, but whether it can continue to honour long-term security commitments while preserving reserves for unforeseen crises. The ability of the United States to simultaneously replenish weapons supplied to Ukraine, support its own forces, and respond to emerging

threats will be closely watched by allies worldwide. For strategic partners such as India, the lesson is significant. Advanced American defence systems provide major operational advantages, but their effectiveness ultimately depends on assured access to ammunition, spare parts, upgrades, and sustainment support during a crisis. Modern warfare has shown that possessing sophisticated platforms is only one component of military power; the industrial ecosystem behind them is equally decisive. A nation may possess superior technology, but without the ability to produce at scale and sustain losses over time, that advantage can rapidly diminish in a prolonged conflict.

The credibility of defence partnerships is therefore measured not only by contracts signed during peacetime, but by the reliability of supply chains during wartime. Allies do not merely purchase weapons; they invest in the promise that those weapons will remain operational when national security is at stake. The Iran conflict has therefore reinforced a strategic imperative for India i.e., accelerate indigenous defence manufacturing while avoiding excessive dependence on any single foreign supplier. Diversification combining domestic production with multiple trusted international partnerships provides insurance against geopolitical shocks, export restrictions, production delays, or the competing demands placed on supplier nations during prolonged conflicts.

Strategic autonomy does not mean isolation. It means ensuring that no external disruption can determine a nation's ability to sustain combat power when it matters most. In future wars, the decisive advantage may belong not only to the country with the most advanced weapons, but to the one capable of producing and sustaining them after the opening phase of conflict has passed.

PIC TALK



People from the Tribal community perform a cultural dance on the International Day of the World's Indigenous Peoples, in Nadia

PHOTO: PTI

Breaking the drug chain: Why community vigil matters



KUMAR ASHISH

Drug abuse is no longer merely a law-and-order challenge. It is a serious threat to public health, family life, social harmony and, above all, the future of our youth. The changing nature of the illegal drug trade-with trafficking networks increasingly exploiting technology and new distribution channels-makes community vigilance more important than ever. The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB)??, India's nodal agency for drug-law enforcement and coordination on drug-related matters, has rightly emphasized that enforcement must go hand in hand with awareness, prevention, demand reduction and rehabilitation. Its nationwide awareness programmes in schools and colleges, community campaigns, rallies and pledge initiatives underline an important truth: the battle against drugs cannot be won by enforcement agencies alone.

As a police officer, I have always believed that the most effective policing is preventive policing. Every consignment of drugs seized is important, every trafficker arrested is a



success, but preventing a young person from becoming a victim of addiction is an even greater achievement.

It was with this philosophy that "Nasha Mukti Koshi Abhiyan" was initiated in the Koshi region of Bihar. Covering Saharsa, Supaul and Madhepura, the initiative seeks to combine stringent enforcement against drug traffickers with active participation of citizens.

A dedicated mechanism was created to enable people to confidentially share information regarding the illegal trade in substances such as cough syrup, smack and ganja. Information received through the helpline is monitored at the senior police level, enabling prompt action and enhanced accountability. Within the initial months of the campaign, coordinated action resulted in the seizure of approximately 4500 kg of ganja and 50,000 litres of illicit liquor, while more than 1,400 persons involved in the illegal trade were sent to jail, according to reports on the cam-

paign. But enforcement is only one side of the battle. Parents, teachers, community leaders and young people themselves must become the first line of defence. Parents should notice sudden behavioural changes, unusual financial demands, withdrawal from family or changes in peer groups. More importantly, children must be approached with empathy and dialogue rather than fear and accusation. We must also remember that a person suffering from addiction needs treatment, counselling and rehabilitation. The objective should be to break the supply chain while simultaneously reducing demand. The NCB's MANAS helpline-1933 provides a national platform through which citizens can report information relating to drug trafficking and seek assistance concerning counselling and rehabilitation, with confidentiality of the informant. The message is therefore simple: Do not ignore. Do not remain silent. Speak up!

The police will continue to act firmly against drug traffickers, but the strength of our action ultimately comes from the trust and participation of citizens. A "Nasha Mukti Bharat" as envisaged by Prime Minister cannot be built by the police alone. It must begin with a Nasha Mukti family, a Nasha Mukti school, a Nasha Mukti neighbourhood and, ultimately, a Nasha Mukti community. Let's come together to deal with this cascading menace by joining hands. Together we can!

The writer is a senior Indian Police Service Officer of the Bihar Cadre & currently posted as DIG Koshi Range, Saharsa

UPI PAYMENTS: END OF GUARANTEE IS A SETBACK TO DIGITAL INDIA

Apropos "Free UPI No Longer Guaranteed" (August 8), the government's decision to remove the legal bar on UPI charges raises important questions about the future of India's digital payments ecosystem. Technically, UPI remains free today. But the statutory guarantee is gone, leaving the possibility of charges being introduced through future notifications.

This distinction matters because UPI has become the backbone of India's digital economy, processing billions of transactions every month. Its remarkable success has been built not only on convenience but also on the public's trust in a simple, low-cost payment system. The proposed charge of 0.25 to 0.4 per cent on high-value merchant payments may appear reasonable. However, the claim that merchants alone will bear the

cost deserves scrutiny. In any market, additional costs can eventually find their way into prices, leaving consumers to pay indirectly.

There is also a larger issue of parliamentary accountability. A change affecting such a fundamental component of everyday economic life deserved extensive debate and public consultation.

There is certainly a case for making UPI financially sustainable, particularly when the government subsidises low-value transactions. But sustainability should not come at the cost of transparency. Any fundamental change to UPI deserves an open debate and clear assurances that the interests of ordinary users will remain paramount.

K CHIDANAND KUMAR | BANGALURU

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Where is India’s youth in politics?

India's youth have made their voices heard on the streets in recent months. Protests in Delhi and the continuing agitation in Jharkhand demonstrate that young Indians are increasingly willing to question governments and demand accountability. Yet an important question remains: why are these voices far less visible in Parliament and state assemblies?

The answer may lie partly in the striking gap between India's youthful population and its political representation. The 14-29 age group, commonly identified with Gen Z, constitutes a substantial share of the country's population, yet only a handful of MPs and a relatively small number of MLAs belong to this age bracket.

The minimum age for contesting Lok Sabha and Assembly elections is 25, while it is 30 for the Rajya Sabha. Should these limits be reconsidered to make our legislatures more representative of a young nation? Even when the age bracket is extended to 40, the disparity remains stark.

The growing popularity of youth-led groups such as the Cockroach Janta Party reflects a deeper dissatisfaction with traditional, entrenched political structures. India needs younger voices in politics.Yours sincerely,

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Protection to live-in relationships

The Supreme Court's recent judgment expanding the scope of Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code is a significant step towards ensuring that women are protected from cruelty and harassment within domestic relationships.The Court has clarified that Section 498A, which protects women against cruelty by a husband or his relatives, can also apply to partners in a live-in relationship when the relationship is in the nature of marriage and there is a clear intention to establish a marital-like partnership. This recognises the changing nature of relationships while ensuring that legal protection keeps pace with social realities.The Court rightly observed that no one enters a relationship expecting to face abuse or harassment. Yet relationships can deteriorate over time.

In such circumstances, the law must provide an effective shield to those facing cruelty.At the same time, safeguards against misuse are equally important. The direction that a man or his relatives should not be arrested solely on the basis of allegations without a preliminary inquiry is therefore welcome.The judgment strikes a careful balance between extending protection to vulnerable women and preventing arbitrary use of criminal law. It is an important recognition that dignity and safety cannot depend solely on marital status.

DATTAPRASAD SHIRODKAR | MUMBAI

Beyond degrees, a larger purpose

Apropos the report, "Keep curiosity alive, PM tells students" (August 9), watching Prime Minister Narendra Modi address the graduating students at IIT Delhi's 57th Convocation was truly a delightful and inspiring experience. His speech went beyond the conventional message of congratulations and offered young engineers a larger purpose to pursue in life.What struck me most was his call to students to measure their careers not merely by pay packages, professional positions or startup valuations, but by the contribution they can make to the nation. His message that important decisions should ultimately be guided by what benefits the country was both timely and profound.His observation that life's most critical challenges are often "out of syllabus" was particularly striking. It reminded the students that their real education begins after graduation, when curiosity, the courage to address unanswered questions and a commitment to continuous learning will matter most. At a time when technology and global equations are changing rapidly, his advice to "keep learning" is perhaps the most relevant mantra for the young generation.The address beautifully connected personal ambition with national responsibility and left a powerful message: India's future will be shaped by the knowledge, character and commitment of its youth.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

The discipline of dissent: When protest meets the state

Protest is essential to a healthy republic, but so are restraint, verification and responsibility. The real test, therefore, is not whether citizens protest or governments respond, but whether both sides can resist the easy certainties of anger and authority—and find a way from confrontation to justice



KANISHK CHAUDHRY

A protest looks like two different events depending on where you are standing. From the street, it is often the last language left to people certain they have not been heard. From the government's side of the aisle, the same event raises other questions too, that of law, of evidence, of public safety, and of the rights of those who never joined the dispute. For those who work at the anvil of due process, these are not incidental questions; they are the work itself. Experience in public service teaches a person to hold both pictures at once, and to grant each its due. That double vision is not indecision; it is the genesis of fair, undramatic judgement. A government that stops listening loses touch with the people it serves; a movement that stops examining itself endangers the cause it carries. The difference is that the state must weigh not one grievance but all of them together, and it is judged, rightly, by how well it holds that balance.

This difficulty has sharpened over time, when an online post lifts in a crowd, a sentence loses its context, an AI image travels as truth. By evening the incident has a slogan, the slogan a hashtag, and the hashtag has dressed itself as a movement. There is something genuinely democratic in that speed: the unheard can reach millions without any institution certifying their pain. Yet the same speed that carries a real concern can carry an error just as far. The task is not to choose between the courage of protest and the patience of verification, but to hold both together. Mahatma Gandhi fused the two in a single word i.e. satyagraha, the holding-firm to truth. He never treated truth as an obstacle to struggle, but as the reason it was worth winning. Seen across the longer arc of history, protest is not the failure of democratic politics but a part of it. Elections, courts and administration each do indispensable work, but none is built to register the immediacy of a grievance shut out at every formal door. Protest enters there. Writing from a Birmingham jail, Martin Luther King called its purpose constructive tension i.e. not disorder for its own sake, but a pressure that makes an urgent wrong impossible to keep overlooking. But that legitimacy carries a price. A disciplined, peaceful protest is, in fact, the hardest form of dissent there is, harder than the riot, which asks only anger, because it asks a crowd to absorb provocation without returning it. The great movements spent years preparing ordinary people to a demanding ethical standard, tested against their own code long before any police line had cause to act. It is this capacity for self-government, more than any slogan, that separates a movement from a mob. Conscience is where it begins. Thoreau's claim, after a night in jail for refusing a tax he believed sustained slavery and an unjust war, was that legality and justice are not the same thing, and that a citizen cannot hand his moral judgement to the law and consider it settled. That principle cuts inward too: institutions are strengthened, not endangered, when officials have the nerve to name an error rather than hide behind procedure. Yet conscience alone is not enough, a person can be sincere and still be wrong. Here John Rawls offers a discipline. Civil disobedience, for him, is a public and conscientious appeal to principles the community already professes - of equal liberty, fair opportunity, due process - undertaken within a fidelity to law, and its practitioners accepting the legal consequences of their act. A protest on such terms says more than "I am angry." It says a principle meant to protect all of us has been broken. Closer home, Ambedkar pressed a harder question. In the Constituent Assembly, he warned against what he called the "grammar of anarchy," arguing that once a people have the ballot, the court and the freedom to petition, there is no warrant left for the older methods of the barricade. That caution carries particular weight for a republic built on exactly those avenues. It reconciles with King on one condition i.e. the moral case for disruptive protest grows only as the ordinary channels are, in truth, blocked. Where the constitutional door genuinely opens, the wiser course is to walk through it, and a mature state keeps it not merely ajar but visibly, dependably open.



A DEMOCRACY IS NOT MADE STRONGER WHEN PROTEST DISAPPEARS, NOR WHEN EVERY PROTEST IS PRESUMED RIGHT. IT IS MADE STRONGER IN EXACTLY SUCH MOMENTS, WHEN CITIZENS ARE REMINDED OF THE RESPONSIBILITY THAT GIVES THEIR DEMANDS WEIGHT

Kanishk Chaudhry writes on spirituality, public policy and governance. He is the author of two books, on power sector reform and the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code

The whole matter rests on one honest question: are the channels we point to actually open, and actually used? Listening asks more of an institution than it first appears: even a government that grants the meeting and issues the reply can, without meaning to, let the real claim slip past into a familiar category, often because the right words for what is actually being said do not yet fully exist. The philosopher José Medina calls this gap epistemic injustice: when a group lacks the words to make its experience intelligible, even a willing listener can mistake something new for something already known, and a real concern arrives without a settled name. It is worth watching for, because anger, read rightly, is often less a claim in itself than a signal of how long the matter went unnamed. But the duty runs both ways, a movement that asks this patience of the state must extend the same rigour to its own account, or forfeit the standing to ask for either. There is also a harder question of what protests can actually do, and here the caution falls on the movement as much as the state. Erica Chenoweth and Maria Stephan found non-violent campaigns succeed roughly twice as often as violent ones, winning by sheer breadth of participation. But numbers are the easy part. A networked crowd, as Zeynep Tufekci says, can turn visible within days and still suffer a "tactical freeze" i.e. unable to negotiate because no one holds the standing to accept an offer. In Egypt in 2011, a leaderless mobilisation removed a government in eighteen days, then found no cadre to hold what followed, and armed forces filled the vacuum. Yet the second act need not fail: a government that meets agitation with patience, rather than a wish to end it, can still draw even a viral crowd to an orderly resolution - as lately seen, when agitation and government met, and found settlement rather than standoff. None of this is an accusation against either side; it is a plea that both carry their share. A government does well to remember that its own genuine complexity (the tangle of statutes, jurisdictions and many hands) can look, from outside, like evasion; and so the answer is not to apologise for that complexity but to make it legible i.e. to locate responsibility, to explain itself in plain language, and to see behind a crowd not merely a question of order but, often, a policy that needs mending or a trust that needs rebuilding. That is competence, not weakness. Equally, a democracy belongs as fully to the worker who cannot reach his site, or the patient who cannot reach hers, as to those who marched. The state that governs for all, and the movement that remembers all, are answerable to the same public. So, before we share a clip, we might ask whether it is complete; before condemning a person, whether responsibility has been established; before assuming the worst of an institution, whether it was given the chance to answer. The network can assemble a crowd in an afternoon; it cannot manufacture trustworthy knowledge or the patience that carries a grievance to settlement. That still asks for character, of citizen and official alike. When a movement disciplines its anger into clear, lawful demands, and a government, secure enough not to stand on prestige, chooses to hear and act, the outcome is not a defeat for authority but an affirmation of it. A democracy is not made stronger when protest disappears, nor when every protest is presumed right. It is made stronger in exactly such moments, when citizens are reminded of the responsibility that gives their demands weight, and the state, by listening, renews the trust on which its own authority rests.

Science is powering India's next agricultural revolution



ASEERVATHAM ACHARY

of sustainable agricultural growth. The global biofertilizer market reflects this transformation. It is expanding rapidly and is projected to reach nearly US\$1.6 billion by 2030. Countries across the world are increasingly investing in biological agriculture as they seek technologies capable of simultaneously improving crop productivity, restoring soil health and reducing environmental stress. India possesses a unique opportunity to lead this global transformation. With world-class scientific expertise in agricultural biotechnology, microbiology, microbial ecology, soil science and precision farming, the country has developed several breakthrough technologies capable of fundamentally transforming nutrient management. Among the most promising innovations is the Multi Nutrient Efficiency Bio Fertilizer Technology, scientifically validated by Maharashtra based Dr. Punjabrao Deshmukh Krishi Vidhyapeeth and Dr.Balasawant Krishi Vidhyapeeth, Indian Institute of Rice Research, Hyderabad and Tamil Nadu Agricultural University in India and globally by All Farmers Association of Nigeria, Rice Growers Association, Togo, West Africa, Benin Rice Growers Association, West Africa and West Jawa, Indonesia using patented microbial consortia containing multiple beneficial bacterial strains capable of improving nutrient uptake from both native soil reserves and applied fertilizers.

Unlike conventional microbial products containing a single microorganism, microbial consortia combine several complementary microorganisms that function synergistically to improve nutrient availability, stimulate root architecture, strengthen soil microbial ecology and enhance overall nutrient use efficiency. Advanced microencapsulation technology further extends shelf life to nearly two years while ensuring sustained release of beneficial microorganisms following field application. Scientific studies have reported nearly a 20 percent increase in cotton yield despite reducing chemical fertiliser application by 25 percent, approximately an 8 percent increase in maize productivity, 12 to 13 percent higher paddy yields under different cultivation systems and significant productivity improvements in Bengal Gram. These findings demonstrate an important scientific principle: higher agricultural productivity does not necessarily require greater fertiliser consumption. Rather, efficient nutrient management through advanced biological technologies can simultaneously enhance yields, reduce cultivation costs and restore long-term soil fertility. This assumes national importance because nearly 50 percent of India's fertiliser consumption is concentrated in only four crops namely Paddy, Cotton, Maize and Bengal Gram. Furthermore, more than 75 percent of fertiliser consumption occurs in just ten States. Improving nutrient use efficiency in these major crops alone has the potential to generate enormous economic, environmental and ecological benefits for the nation. India therefore stands at the threshold of a new agricultural revolution where biology, biotechnology, microbial sciences and precision agriculture are gradually replacing excessive dependence on chemical inputs. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has consistently maintained that the future of Indian agriculture lies in restoring soil health while improving farmers' prosperity. His government has therefore adopted a balanced and science-based approach that does not advocate the complete replacement of chemical fertilisers overnight. Instead, it promotes balanced nutrient management by integrating biofertilisers, nano fertilisers, organic inputs and precision farming with conventional fertilisers.

Balanced fertiliser management is not merely an agricultural reform; it is also an important economic reform. India spends approximately ₹1.71 lakh crore annually on fertiliser subsidies. Scientifically validated technologies capable of reducing fertiliser consumption by even 25 percent without compromising productivity can generate substantial savings for the national exchequer. These savings can be redirected towards agricultural research, irrigation infrastructure, farm mechanisation, digital agriculture, climate adaptation and rural development. Like the Indian IT industry boom, for Indian Agricultural Biotechnology boom to happen, private players with strong scientific foundation need to be supported for faster and adoption in scale in the larger interest of farmers. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has repeatedly reminded the nation that agriculture cannot prosper by exhausting Mother Earth. His government's emphasis on balanced fertiliser use, Soil Health Management, Nano Fertilisers, Neem Coated Urea, PM PRANAM, ICAR research and promotion of biofertilisers reflects a long-term vision that combines scientific innovation with ecological sustainability. Reduced fertiliser consumption also lowers India's dependence on imported raw materials, strengthens supply chain resilience, improves foreign exchange savings and enhances national food security. Most importantly, lower cultivation costs combined with higher productivity directly contribute to the Government's objective of increasing farmers' income.

The future of Indian agriculture lies not in applying larger quantities of chemical fertilisers but in applying greater scientific knowledge, biotechnology, precision agriculture and innovation. India now has a historic opportunity to emerge as a global leader in sustainable agriculture. By embracing biofertilisers, microbial biotechnology and advanced biological innovations, the country can build an agricultural system that is highly productive, economically profitable, environmentally responsible and resilient to climate change.

The journey from Food Security to Soil Security has already begun. Under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India is laying the scientific foundation for an agricultural model that not only feeds the nation but also regenerates its soils, empowers its farmers, strengthens long-term food security and preserves Mother Earth for generations to come.



The writer is National Coordinator of Digital Library & Documentation, BJP

World Lion Day 2026: Gujarat's Asiatic Lion triumph, and challenges ahead



VK BAHUGUNA

celebration began as a global awareness initiative in 2013 has become a proud annual celebration across Saurashtra, where the species has staged one of the most remarkable recoveries in modern wildlife conservation. Gujarat's efforts deserve genuine recognition. The Gujarat model's strict protection, political will, especially the tolerance of the Maldhari community, restoration of the prey base, high-tech monitoring, the dedication of Gujarat's IFS officers and other Forest Department staff to their work, adequate funding, and political support are the main reasons why the status of Asiatic lions in the country is good. Eco-tourism has linked local livelihoods to the presence of lions. These achievements resonate globally; the Asiatic lion remains the only stable northern lion subpopulation of significant size. Yet numerical success alone does not guarantee long-term security. The stalled debate over relocation, Gujarat's consistent refusal to share lions outside the state, and the unfinished task of true population diversification remain central challenges. It is worth mentioning that when I joined service in 1979 there were only

205 Lion in Gir and therefore the conservation narrative is impressive. From a precarious low of fewer than 50 individuals in the early 20th century and around 284 in the early 1990s, the population reached 674 in the 2020 census and climbed to 891 by the May 2025 estimation-an increase of roughly 32 percent in five years and more than 70 percent over a decade. Lions now range across approximately 35,000 square kilometres in 11 districts. However, about half of the population lives in nine satellite groups outside the core Gir Protected Area. Varda Wildlife Sanctuary, now supports a small growing population after 143 years after natural migration and assisted translocation, and is officially positioned as a second habitat under Project Lion. Once ranged widely across Southwest Asia and northern India. Its historical distribution stretched from Turkey, Syria, and through Iraq, Iran, and southern Pakistan into the Indian subcontinent-as far east as Bihar and as far south as the Narmada River in central India. Lions reached the Indian region thousands of years ago and featured prominently in art, culture, and hunting records from ancient times through the Mughal era. In India, lions remained relatively abundant into the early-mid 19th century across the Indo-Gangetic plains, Rajasthan, Haryana, Gujarat, and parts of central India. Outside India, populations persisted longer in isolated pockets of Iran and Iraq but steadily dwindled. The collapse accelerated in the 19th century due to two main factors: intensive hunting by cowardice British (as one British officer reportedly shot hundreds of lions around the time of the 1857 rebel-



lion) and Indian elite classes and habitat loss from agricultural expansion. Lion survived in Gir because the Nawab of Junagadh who used Gir as his private hunting grounds from the late 19th century onward and banned or severely restricting hunting. After Indian independence, formal protection intensified: Gir was declared a wildlife sanctuary in 1965 and hunting was fully banned, and management improved habitat. The population rose from 177 in 1968 to several hundred by the early 2000s, and 891 by the 2025 census. Today the entire wild Asiatic lion population remains restricted to the Gir and satellite areas in Gujarat-the sole surviving free-ranging group of what was once a vast Southwest Asian range. The single-population status leaves the subspecies vulnerable to disease, natural disasters, and other risks. Asiatic lion remains the only stable northern lion subpopulation of significant size. The entire free-ranging population remains confined to a single contiguous landscape in Saurashtra. This geographic concentration is the species' greatest

existential risk. The 2018 canine distemper virus outbreak that killed more than 20 lions must awaken the foresters. More recent clusters of deaths linked to babesiosis, suspected CDV, and even rabies in 2026 show that pathogens can still move rapidly through a connected population. Low genetic diversity from the historic bottleneck compounds susceptibility. Gir forests have exceeded its estimated ecological carrying capacity for Lion. Expansion into farmlands, coastal thickets, and peri-urban zones has increased livestock depredation and occasional human casualties. Unnatural mortality from open wells, electrocution, and accidents continues. There is still the long-standing and unresolved question of relocation. In a judgment of 15 April 2013, the Supreme Court of India directed the translocation of a viable founding population of Asiatic lions from Gir to Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh within six months. The Court emphasised that the lions are a national heritage, not the exclusive property of any one state, and that a second, geographically isolated population was essential to guard against the risk of a single epidemic, fire, or disaster wiping out the species. Kuno had been prepared for this purpose-villages were relocated and habitat restored-following earlier recommendations by the Wildlife Institute of India. Gujarat has consistently refused to implement the order. Successive state governments have cited the success of their own conservation model, concerns about habitat suitability and disease risks in Kuno, climatic differences, and the cultural and tourism significance of the lions as Gujarat's

exclusive pride. Meanwhile, Kuno has been used for the reintroduction of African cheetahs and as on July 54 Cheetahs are doing well. The tasks ahead therefore require ; first, disease surveillance, veterinary rapid-response capacity, and interface management with domestic animals must be strengthened across the entire landscape; second, habitat and corridor integrity outside protected areas need rigorous protection against industrial intrusion, while conflict-mitigation measures-timely compensation, predator-proof livestock systems, and community incentives-must be scaled up. On finding a new habitat, a balanced will have to be ensured if not today but surely in future if we plan ahead for Lion population 15 years from now. Gujarat's pride in its conservation achievement is praiseworthy and is real. Varda and other satellite populations should continue to be strengthened however, a truly isolated second population is essential for establishing a geographically separate population or identifying alternative sites. Future Lion conservation should be considered not as a loss of Gujarat's pride but as an act of national duty to strengthens the species Gujarat has so successfully recovered. We need to draw a Project Lion's vision 2047 and back up Gujarat's extraordinary chapter in conservation history, so that the roar that now echoes across Saurashtra remains secure for generations to come.

The writer is former Director-General and Chancellor of ICFRE, Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change Government of India



**TRANSGLOBE
ADVISORS**

**Your Trusted
Management
Advisory**

www.transglobeadvisors.in



Order Order

Thane court sentences man to life for killing cousin



A court in Maharashtra's Thane district has sentenced a 40-year-old man to life imprisonment after convicting him of kidnapping and killing his cousin over money disputes more than 11 years ago.

In his order of August 5, a copy of which was made available on Saturday, Additional Sessions Judge R V Tamhanekar from Kalyan also imposed a fine of Rs 10,000 on the convict, Husen Harun Shaikh, a resident of the Ulhasnagar area.

According to the prosecution, the victim, Ramjan Shahavali Shaikh, went missing on July 25, 2015, after the accused had demanded money from him for alcohol and ganja and threatened him.

The victim's decomposed body was later recovered on August 1, 2015, from a drainage channel following threatening phone calls made by the accused to his family.

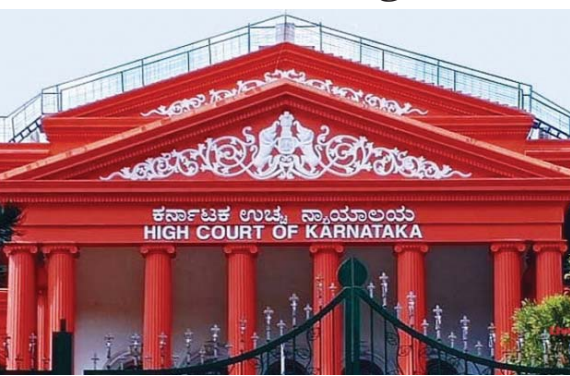
Additional Public Prosecutor Kadambini M Khandagale examined as many as ten prosecution witnesses.

The court found Husen guilty under Sections 302 (murder), 364 (kidnapping to murder), 201 (causing disappearance of evidence), and 507 (criminal intimidation by anonymous communication) of the Indian Penal Code.

The court awarded life imprisonment to Husen for murder, 10 years rigorous imprisonment for kidnapping, 5 years for destroying evidence, and 1 year for criminal intimidation, with all sentences to run concurrently.

(PTI)

Six additional judges sworn in at Karnataka High Court



Six new additional judges of the Karnataka High Court were sworn in on Sunday, with Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot administering the oath of office at a ceremony in Bengaluru. The newly appointed additional judges are Raghavendra Seetharam Shrivatsa, Hema Kulkarni, Subrahmanya Rangarao, Tadagawadi Prakash Vivekananda, Bakkeshwara Pramod and Hombegowda Shanthi Bhushan.

The ceremony was held at the Glass House of Lok Bhavan in Bengaluru. Chief Minister DK Shivakumar and Karnataka High Court Chief Justice Vibhu Bakhru attended the ceremony, along with other judges, advocates, dignitaries and senior government officials.

(PTI)

Madras HC gets 15 new judges

Eight advocates and seven judicial officers were on Sunday sworn in as judges of the Madras High Court.

At a simple function held on the HC premises, Chief Justice SA Dharmadhikari administered the oath of office to the new judges. With their appointment, the total number of judges in the High Court has gone up to 66, as against the sanctioned strength of 75. The newly appointed permanent judges were Krishnaswamy Govindarajan, Rajnish Pathiyil, Natarajan Ramesh, GK Muthukumar and Ramakrishnan Rajesh Vivekananthan. Additional judges appointed for a period of two years from the Bar were Sankaranarayanan Raveekumar, Nagarajan Dilip Kumar and Ellappan Manoharan. Judicial officers elevated as additional judges for a period of two years were Dr P Murugan, MD Sumathi, S Alli, C Thirumagal Chandrasekar, Shanmugam Karthikeyan, Baluchamy Murugesan and N Gunasekaran.

(PNS)

Patna HC orders CBI probe into disappearance of man from police detention

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The Patna High Court has ordered a CBI probe into the disappearance of a man who went missing after being detained by Excise Police officials in Bihar's Bhojpur district one year ago.

The court stated that the police investigation into the case was biased, and the investigators did not show urgency after an FIR was lodged in this regard.

It was alleged that Sanoj Kumar, a centring mason, was detained on the charge of consuming liquor near a Kali temple at Dharahara Musahar Toli in Bihiya police

Ranchi student agitation highlights need for timely judicial and State intervention



RANJIT KUMAR SINHA

There has been no judicial intervention by either the Supreme Court or the Jharkhand High Court in the ongoing student agitation and hunger strike in Ranchi.

Judges are not deciding the matter. Instead, it is being handled through direct talks and negotiations between student leaders and State Government ministers.

The protest remains entirely a ground movement. Students are running their hunger strike and making demands directly to the state administration without any court orders guiding the process.

This is the story of a fortnight-long agitation in Jharkhand's capital Ranchi. The demand is clear: cancellation of the 14th Jharkhand Public Services Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC) examinations, a CBI probe into recruitment irregularities, and sweeping administrative reforms. The agitation began as a grassroots protest by job aspirants in Ranchi over alleged paper leaks and evaluation errors in these key competitive examinations.

The movement intensified into indefinite hunger strikes, drawing widespread State attention and political backing as the health of fasting student leaders required urgent medical care.

Despite the growing scale of the street protests, neither the High Court nor the Supreme Court has stepped in with direct judicial orders or suo motu action.

Instead of a legal battle in court, the deadlock is being managed through administrative dialogue between state ministers and student delegations, alongside an active CID investigation. Even

though official channels and ministerial committees have opened up for talks, the slow pace of executive resolution highlights why timely judicial intervention may become necessary. Much like high-profile national demonstrations at places like Jantar Mantar, this protracted standoff directly implicates core constitutional protections. Specifically, it touches the inter-linked boundaries of the right to peaceful protest under Article 19 and the right to life and health under Article 21 for young protesters fasting indefinitely. Protesting is a constitutional right, but when fasting threatens the lives of young citizens, the state carries a constitutional obligation to protect them.

Many student leaders have fallen sick and ended up in the hospital during the tough hunger strike.

Court supervision could help speed up negotiations. It would ensure the government protects the health and basic human rights of the fasting protesters. Judicial oversight also brings a sense of neutrality to administrative talks, ensuring that promises made by ministerial panels are backed by legal enforceability. Unlike other high-profile agitations across the country, the Ranchi protest has been entirely peaceful. The student leaders gave no provocation for violence.

The students deliberately kept politicians and outside trouble-makers away from their stage. They wanted to keep the focus clean and strictly on their educational demands. Unlike the demonstrations at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi, there were no aggressive or anti-government slogans raised here. The tone remained disciplined and focused. This discipline shows that it is a genuine, pure student movement fighting responsibly for its future rights and career security.

Further, unlike some national capital agitations that face complex allegations of foreign funding and



heavy logistical support, the Ranchi protest has no such shadows.

The protesters are ordinary youth and students coming directly from small towns and villages across Jharkhand. They have little connection to the high-profile networks, political groups, or institutional backers who often jump into demonstrations staged in New Delhi. Their struggle is driven purely by personal sacrifice, pooled resources, and the shared anxiety of losing years of hard work to administrative negligence. Also, the present crisis is not an isolated event. Past recruitment exams in Jharkhand have repeatedly faced severe controversies, paper leak scandals, and long legal battles.

These recurring failures cause severe delays, immense mental stress to students, and shatter public faith in state examination bodies. For thousands of young job seekers, an exam delay of two or three years means crossing the age limit for government employment entirely. Given this background, the State Government must step forward with clear, concrete, and time-bound guarantees to end this recurring cycle once and for all.

While executive committees and CID inquiries are helpful, they often

lack the strict timelines and binding authority that court directives possess. If executive talks fail to yield immediate results, there is a strong case for the Jharkhand High Court to step in suo motu.

Court oversight is essential to protect the health, welfare, and fundamental rights of the fasting students before the situation worsens.

Bringing judicial attention to the Ranchi protest can also add valuable perspective to national legal jurisprudence.

It will help the Supreme Court frame broader, much-needed guidelines on student protests, addressing issues raised in pending petitions arising out of national demonstrations at the Jantar Mantar. Judicial intervention in the Jharkhand protest could create a strong procedural model for other states to follow.

It would help build a clear, standardised mechanism to stop frequent paper leaks and job exam corruption everywhere. Systemic reforms could include setting up independent exam auditing bodies and establishing special fast-track courts to resolve recruitment disputes within fixed timelines. Steps taken at the state level would address the root causes that usually

trigger massive national demonstrations. Such proactive steps are vital to win back the trust of the youth, Gen Z, and Gen Alpha job seekers. It proves to the new generation that the public administration values their hard work and future prospects. Beyond just managing individual protests, a firm judicial or executive directive could compel states to adopt strict anti-paper leak legislation with non-bailable penalties. It would mandate fast-track mechanisms for exam disputes, stopping these crises before they erupt on the streets. Any further delay by the authorities can make the ground situation significantly worse. A prolonged deadlock risks turning a peaceful student movement into a chaotic flashpoint.

Outsiders, political outfits, and their student wings are trying hard to jump into the agitation to hijack it for political gains.

If the Government moves too slowly and the judiciary maintains a wait-and-watch policy, the core issues of the students will get sidelined by political friction. We saw an unpleasant outcome in Delhi when delayed action by authorities led to unnecessary clashes and administrative chaos. Timely intervention in Ranchi is vital to protect the pure intent of the students and prevent outside interference. The ongoing standoff in Ranchi has reached a fragile tipping point that requires immediate attention.

Protesters demand immediate accountability and systemic reform, while authorities navigate sensitive administrative talks. Timely action is essential. Any prolonged vacuum invites political opportunism, risking the organic purity of a genuine student-led movement. To safeguard student welfare and prevent escalation, proactive judicial oversight or decisive executive guarantees remain the ultimate path forward.

The writer is a senior journalist covering legal affairs.

SC to hear plea seeking NDPS probes, confiscation of traffickers' properties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is slated to hear on Monday a plea seeking a slew of directions to strengthen the fight against drug trafficking, including time-bound investigation and trial of narcotics cases, confiscation of properties of traffickers and creation of a uniform investigation protocol across the country.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana is likely to hear the matter. The PIL, filed by advocate Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay, has sought directions to the Centre and states to prescribe mandatory timelines for submission of forensic reports in cases under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act and frame standard operating procedures (SOPs) for search, seizure and sampling of narcotic substances. "Keeping in view the menace of drug mafia network operating in India, the court may be pleased to issue a writ, order or direction to, a) direct the Centre and state governments to prescribe a mandatory timeline for submission of FSL (forensic science laboratory) reports in all NDPS cases; b) direct the Centre and states to formulate a SOP for search, seizure and sampling in small and intermediate quantity cases," read the plea filed through advocate Ashwani



Kumar Dubey. The petition also sought constitution of special courts for speedy trial of NDPS cases and implementation of mandatory digital recording and videography of search, seizure and sampling proceedings.

Claiming that drug abuse and trafficking had assumed alarming proportions, the plea said there was a 53 per cent rise in drug cases in 2025 and 1,240 tonnes of narcotic substances were seized during the year, indicating the growing scale of the problem. It referred to incidents from Punjab and other states to argue that drug addiction was destroying families and affecting public health and law and order. The plea said the existing framework lacked uniform investigation standards, time-bound forensic examination and effective coordination among enforcement agencies, leading to delays in prosecution and avoidable acquittals. Seeking stricter action against organised drug syndicates, the petition urged the court to direct authorities to carry out time-bound assess-

ment and confiscation of properties of traffickers, financiers and their family members under the NDPS Act, Prevention of Money Laundering Act, Benami Property Act and Black Money Act. "Direct the Centre to constitute an Expert Committee for identification and timely scheduling of New Psychoactive Substances and constitute Special Courts under Sections 36 and 36A, and frame SOP for time-bound investigation and speedy trial," it said. The plea further sought directions for the creation of an expert committee to identify and regulate new psychoactive substances, establishment of rehabilitation and wellness centres for addicts and formulation of a graded sentencing policy that distinguishes traffickers and financiers from addicts and personal-use offenders.

The petitioner has also sought a direction to the Law Commission to prepare a comprehensive report on the issue and a declaration that sentences in NDPS cases should run consecutively.

Excise case: Delhi HC to hear ED plea against Kejriwal's bail today

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court will on Monday hear the Enforcement Directorate's plea challenging the bail granted to former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal in the 2021-22 excise policy-linked money laundering case.

The Enforcement Directorate's (ED) petition, filed in 2024, is listed for hearing before Justice Manoj Jain. Kejriwal has been since granted relief in the case by the Supreme Court.

On July 12, 2024, the top court granted interim bail to Kejriwal in the money laundering case while referring to a larger bench three questions on the aspect of "need



and necessity of arrest" under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). Earlier, on June 20, 2024, Kejriwal was granted bail by a trial court on a personal bond of ₹1 lakh, which was subsequently stayed by the high court on the ED's petition. On October 14, 2025, the high court granted a "last and final opportunity" to the agency to argue the petition. Kejriwal's counsel

objected to the "repeated" adjournments sought by the agency in the case, accusing it of prolonging the proceedings without any reason. The AAP national convenor was arrested by the ED and the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on March 21 and June 26, 2024, respectively, in the money laundering and corruption cases. The excise policy was scrapped in 2022 after the Delhi LG ordered a CBI probe into alleged irregularities and corruption involving its formulation and execution. According to the CBI and the ED, irregularities were committed while modifying the excise policy and undue favours extended to licence holders.

Ideological pollution at root of environmental crisis: Ex-SC judge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Latur

Ideological pollution is the root of all environmental degradation, and it continues to drive ecological damage through a lack of civic awareness, diminishing sensitivity toward nature, and social and political inaction, former Supreme Court judge Justice Abhay Oka has said.

Speaking at a gathering at Dayananand Law College in Latur on Saturday, the

former judge said that while citizens possess a constitutional right to live in a pollution-free environment, society continues to suffer due to widespread indifference towards following the law.

Oka was the chief guest at the inauguration of a new seminar hall and spoke at the 'Nyay Samvad: Law, Environment and Citizens' programme at the college. "Along with air, water and noise pollution, there is

another, less visible form of pollution - ideological pollution - which is at the root of all other forms of environmental degradation," Oka said. He noted that while citizens have a constitutional right to live in a pollution-free environment, society continues to live amid pollution due to a lack of awareness about duties, diminishing sensitivity towards nature, indifference towards following laws, and social and political inaction.



and Surendra Kumar Singh were marked as suspects by the police.

Describing it as one of the

"rare and exceptional cases," the court said it warranted transfer of the investigation to an independent agency

such as CBI, especially since several Excise Police officials were suspects in the case and the progress had been tardy over the year gone by.

"Bias on the part of the state investigating agency may be clearly deduced from their inaction," the bench observed, adding that two accused ASIs were in a "position to influence the investigation." The court said it had "no iota of doubt" that the state investigating agency had failed to show urgency after the FIR was registered.

Local witnesses were not promptly examined, material witnesses were not produced before a magistrate and meaningful steps to

interrogate suspects and collect scientific evidence were not taken for a considerable period of time, the court noted.

The court recorded that Excise officials repeatedly changed their statement, eventually settling on the assertion that they detained five individuals, of whom two were released after a breath-analyser test. The remaining three were taken in a police vehicle towards Bihiya Chaurasta, but one man jumped from the vehicle and fled.

The court observed that the doors of the vehicle in which the men were taken were closed from outside, and

unless the rear door was opened, it would not be possible for anyone to jump outside and escape.

Investigations revealed that there was a scuffle involving Sanoj and the excise vehicle's private driver who had put a towel around the detainee's neck and pulled him, the court order noted. The bench also directed the CBI to constitute a team of reputed officers and said the agency would be free to interrogate police officials connected with the earlier investigation.

The CBI has been directed to submit an action-taken report by the next hearing on September 11.

FROM THE WORLD

RUSSIA

Eyes Indian Ocean rail link

Russia needs to create a railway route to the Indian Ocean to reduce dependence on strategically sensitive maritime chokepoints like the Strait of Hormuz and the Bosphorus Strait, Russian Deputy Prime Minister Marat Khusnullin has said. His comments came amid the conflict in West Asia, which has severely disrupted shipping through the Strait of Hormuz – a waterway through which roughly one-fifth of the world's energy supplies pass in normal times.

"A rail link to the Indian Ocean should also be explored. Risks related to the Bosphorus and the Strait of Hormuz might require alternative routes: through Turkmenistan, Iran, Afghanistan, and Pakistan. Any options providing access to India are acceptable," Khusnullin told Russia's State-run TASS news agency on Thursday. (PTI)

PAKISTAN

Forces kills 15 terrorists

Pakistani security forces have killed 15 terrorists in separate sanitisation operations in different parts of the restive Balochistan province, State-run media said on Sunday. The terrorists were killed in the separate operations in Mastung, Bolan, Washuk, Awaran, Sibi, Khuzdar, Harnai, and Nushki areas during Operation Raddul Fitna 3 carried out over a week, it said.

The security forces also recovered a large quantity of weapons and ammunition from the slain terrorists during the operations. "The operations severely damaged the khawarij network and restricted their movement," Pakistan TV said.

Security forces, including the military, have been carrying out clean-up operations in Balochistan since last month after a spate of attacks by the insurgent groups, especially one incident which saw 27 policemen killed in Ziarat on July 6. (PTI)

China issues red alert as Typhoon Dolphin hits its eastern coast

KJM VARMA
■ Beijing

China's national observatory issued a red alert – the highest level in the country's typhoon warning system as Typhoon Dolphin hit Zhejiang province on the eastern coast on Sunday afternoon.

Typhoon Dolphin made landfall along the country's east coast from Sanmen in Zhejiang Province to Fuding in Fujian Province, the National Meteorological Centre (NMC) said.

Wang Haiping, NMC chief forecaster, said a high alert was required due to the typhoon's heavy rainfall intensity, extensive impact range and prolonged duration.

From Sunday to Wednesday, regions including northern Fujian, Zhejiang, Shanghai, northern Jiangxi, Jiangsu, Anhui, eastern Hubei, central and eastern Henan, and southern Shandong will be hit by heavy downpours, with some areas in central-eastern Zhejiang and southern Anhui facing severe torrential rain.

Addressing key areas of



Modi-Rahman meeting can ease India-Bangladesh ties: Envoy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's meeting with his Indian counterpart Narendra Modi could resolve strains in bilateral ties, Indian High Commissioner in Dhaka Dinesh Trivedi said on Sunday.

His comments come amid speculations that Rahman, who has been invited by India to attend the BRICS summit in New Delhi, may skip the event scheduled for September 12-13.

Relations between India and Bangladesh have witnessed strain after former Bangladesh prime minister Sheikh Hasina virtually addressed the press on August 5 in New Delhi, where she said she is determined to return home in December to put the country on the "right track" by restoring democracy, notwithstanding the risk of facing the threat of imprisonment or a death sentence.

Bangladesh expressed outrage over the media interaction, saying the event has hurt the sentiments of its people and could adversely affect efforts to improve bilateral ties with India.

However, India's Ministry of External Affairs on August



Indian High Commissioner in Dhaka Dinesh Trivedi

7 confirmed that it had no role in the media event concerning Hasina and it does not endorse anything said at the forum about the Bangladesh Government.

"When two leaders meet, a lot of problems are solved. I have full confidence [about the problem resolution through the meeting]," said Trivedi at an event in a visa application centre in Dhaka.

"We all respect Bangladesh PM Tarique Rahman a lot. He is a people's person, and our PM is also a people's person", he said.

"I am very confident," he added. "There is nothing negative. Things remain positive."

Trivedi, a senior leader of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party, is the first politician to serve as the Indian high commissioner to Bangladesh, with the status of a union minister, who arrived in the country on June 12.

He is scheduled to meet Rahman on Monday.

Hasina's Government was toppled in August 2024, after violent student-led street protests, forcing her to flee to India.

In November 2025, Hasina was sentenced to death, in absentia, by a special tribunal in Dhaka for alleged "crimes against humanity" over her Government's brutal crackdown on protesters in 2024. Since the verdict, Dhaka has been urging New Delhi to extradite her to face the law.

The current Government in

Bangladesh - led by Rahman's Bangladesh Nationalist Party - maintains that Hasina shall have to surrender and face the law if she returns.

India's ties with Bangladesh had turned frosty under an interim Government led by Muhammad Yunus, which succeeded Hasina's Awami league, especially over the ousted leader's extradition, border-related issues and Dhaka's foreign policy pivot toward China.

But the relations experienced a cautious and uneasy reset after the new Government under Rahman took charge in February.

In that context, the August 5 press interaction marks a new flashpoint between the two neighbouring countries.

On Sunday, the Prothom Alo newspaper in Bangladesh reported that it is "almost certain" Rahman would skip India's invitation to participate in the BRICS summit as tensions mounted afresh in bilateral ties over Hasina's August 5 virtual press interaction in New Delhi.

Citing unidentified sources, the newspaper said: "The recent situation virtually shut the possibility of the premier's participation in BRICS outreach."

Pak-Saudi-Turkiye defence pact not against any country: Dy PM Dar

M ZULQERNAIN
■ Lahore

Pakistan Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar said on Sunday that the defence pact signed between Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Turkiye is "purely defensive" in nature and it is not "targeted against any country".

Dar also said that the accord remains "open to any country in the region willing to uphold its fundamental principles".

The Makkah Joint Defence Agreement was signed on Friday by Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, Saudi Crown Prince and Prime Minister Mohammed bin Salman and Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan at the Al-Safa Palace in Islam's holiest city of Mecca.

Under the agreement, an armed attack against any one of the three countries will be regarded as an attack against all three.

In a post on his X account on Sunday, Dar, who is also the foreign minister, provided additional context about the defence agreement.

He said the pact reflects the "depth of the brotherly relations between the leadership and peoples of the three countries".



Pakistan Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar

Dar called it the culmination of years of discussions and coordination, with "a common desire to strengthen strategic cooperation in addressing multifarious peace and security challenges and advancing regional peace, stability and prosperity."

The foreign minister added that the pact does not abrogate or replace any existing bilateral or multilateral agreements between

the three countries, or with other countries or organisations.

"The Makkah Accord is purely defensive in nature. It is not targeted against any country and its sole purpose is to further strengthen our ongoing efforts towards peace, stability and prosperity in the wider region," Dar said, adding any external armed attack on any one of the three countries will be considered as an attack on all, consistent with the inherent right of individ-

ual and collective self-defence under Article 51 of the UN Charter.

He further said: "Makkah Accord remains open to any country in the region willing to uphold its fundamental principles and resolve differences through mutual respect, cooperation and peaceful means."

Asserting that the agreement is consistent with the fundamental pillars of Pakistan's foreign policy, he said the country "looks forward to continuing to work closely with all brotherly countries in the region towards lasting peace and stability".

"We remain committed to advancing the cause of peaceful resolution of all conflicts and building a more secure, stable and prosperous future for our peoples," Dar said.

The pact comes as the conflict in West Asia has widened across multiple fronts, including the Red Sea and the Bab al-Mandeb Strait, prompting Gulf states to strengthen regional security coordination.

Pakistan, which has sought to play a mediatory role between the US and Iran, said last week that it was "doing its utmost" to bring the two sides back to the negotiating table under a Memorandum of Understanding signed in June. (PTI)

Myanmar junta rebuffs ASEAN call to free Aung San Suu Kyi, questions need for envoy

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bangkok

Myanmar's military-backed Government has rejected the Association of Southeast Asian Nations' renewed call for the unconditional release of detained former leader Aung San Suu Kyi and dismissed the need for the organization's special envoy on Myanmar, according to the foreign affairs ministry.

President Min Aung Hlaing, the former army chief who had originally seized power in 2021 from Suu Kyi's civilian Government, has been trying to win political legitimacy since the takeover



and resume relations with ASEAN.

ASEAN came up with a peace plan for the Southeast Asian country in April 2021 to

end hostilities and initiate dialogue among contending parties, to be facilitated by the special envoy. Min Aung Hlaing has since been

UK PM Andy Burnham plans cost-of-living tour to reassure voters

ADITI KHANNA
■ London

British Prime Minister Andy Burnham will set off on a nationwide tour to hear people's cost-of-living concerns and unveil a set of measures to give them some "room to breathe", officials said on Sunday.

Burnham, who replaced Keir Starmer at 10 Downing Street last month, will spend the rest of the parliamentary summer recess month of August in "listening mode" as he travels around the country. He also plans to use the so-called cost-of-living tour to tell voters about his 10-year plan for the UK.

"He [Burnham] thinks Westminster has got used to telling people that everyday hassles – like hidden pricing and consumers being ripped off – must be accepted as part of life," a Downing Street spokesperson said.

"He doesn't think that's right. That's why he's going to start rolling out a series of pro-consumer cost of living measures to give people some room to breathe," the spokesperson said.

Rising inflation and everyday living costs remain one of the top concerns for the British public as the fallout of the war in West Asia continues to have a knock-on effect around the world.



"He's also going to be kicking off his summer tour around the country, getting out of Westminster and meeting people where they are. The Prime Minister is

Russia, Ukraine exchange overnight strikes that leave 7 dead, many injured

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kyiv (Ukraine)

Russia and Ukraine exchanged strikes overnight that killed civilians and injured many others on both sides, local authorities reported.

In Russia's border region of Belgorod, Ukrainian drones killed five people and injured two dozen others, including a 4-year-old boy, according to the regional administration.

Russian missiles struck a high-rise apartment block in Kharkiv's Saltivskiy district, killing two people and injuring 13, according to regional head Oleh Syniehubov. Eight more people were injured in Ukraine's Black Sea port of Odesa after "dozens of missiles and drones" struck the city and surrounding region, according to local administration head Oleh Kiper.

Large-scale Russian missile strikes on Ukrainian cities have become almost routine in recent weeks, with Moscow exploiting Ukraine's critical shortage of interceptors for the US-made Patriot systems - the sole air defence weapon in its arsenal able to shoot down ballistic missiles.

Ukraine's President



Volodymyr Zelenskyy has for months lobbied other countries, especially the US, to send Ukraine more Patriot systems made scarcer by the Iran war, arguing they are crucial for defending civilians.

Failing that, Zelenskyy wants to make Patriot ammunition in Ukraine or get approval from Elon Musk to use his Starlink satellite communications system to guide strikes inside Russia that can hit its missile launchers.

Meanwhile, Kyiv has kept up long-range drone strikes against Russian energy infrastructure, as well as the country's largest online retailer, Wildberries, and other targets deep inside

Russia, sparking a fuel crisis.

Russia's defence ministry on Sunday claimed its overnight strikes hit drone warehouses in the Kharkiv region, as well as fuel depots and stores of other materiel belonging to Ukraine's armed forces at the port of Odesa.

It said its forces had shot down 153 Ukrainian drones during the night, including over Russian-occupied Crimea and the Black and Azov seas.

In Russia's Belgorod region, the authorities said Ukrainian drone strikes damaged 29 apartment blocks and five private houses, as well as administrative buildings and unspecified "commercial facilities."

8 parties join hands to form Progressive Front in Nepal



SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

Eight Nepalese political parties have announced the formation of a new alliance named the 'Progressive Front' based on "shared political issues and common agendas."

The alliance was announced at a programme held in Kathmandu on Saturday comprising Janata Samajbadi Party (JSP), Janamat Party (JP), Aam Janata Party (AJP), Nagarik Unmukti Party Nepal (NUPN), Pragatishil Loktantrik Party (PLP), Nepal Sanghiya Samjawadi Party (NSSP), Bahujan Samajbadi Party Nepal (BSPN) and Khambuwan Rastriya Morcha (KRM).

According to a statement issued by the Progressive Front, the alliance is preparing to move forward on the basis of shared political issues and common agendas.

The formation comes amid ongoing efforts among Madhesh-based parties and some other fringe parties to forge political collaboration and cooperation. The front aims to work for the formation of a "just, inclusive and discrimination-less unified society" by ending all types of discrimination and anomalies irrespective of the people's castes,

creed and classes, the statement said.

"The front also aims to institutionalise and develop a federal, democratic, republic governance system and an inclusive democratic system in practical terms," it said.

The alliance also seeks to ensure equal and proportionate representation based on population in the parliament, both the House of Representatives and the National Assembly, as well as provincial assemblies.

The front said it aims to end all types of exploitation, inequalities and discrimination against Madhesi, ethnic groups, Dalits, women, Tharu, Muslims, backward classes and sexual minorities.

According to experts, the new alliance is expected to have an impact on Nepal's political scenario despite not having representation in the federal parliament.

Those who signed the joint statement include Upendra Yadav from JSP, CK Raut from Janamat Party, Prabhu Sah from AJP, Resham Chaudhari from NUPN, Santosh Pariyar from PLP, Rijwan Ansari from NSSP, Harinandah K. Ranjan from BSPN and Ram Kumar Rai from KRM.

The alliance comes days after communal clashes rocked Koshi and Madhes Provinces of Nepal. (PTI)

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

The Pioneer



NEW DELHI | MONDAY | AUGUST 10, 2026

BUSINESS13

BIS to scales up silver testing as buyers shift from gold

The Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) is preparing to scale up testing of silver jewellery as demand shifts from gold amid a spike in prices, a senior BIS official said, adding that referral and assay laboratories for silver will expand nationally within two years.

Silver hallmarking has been voluntary since 2005, and from September 2025 onwards, hallmarked silver articles carry a Hallmark Unique Identification (HUID) number, enabling buyers to verify purity.

“Last year, we introduced HUID for silver jewellery as well, and demand is increasing. We have taken stock of the requirements and are ready to take up silver jewellery testing in a big way in our laboratories,” BIS Deputy Director General (Laboratories) Nishat S Haque said.

“We will be able to handle the requirement within our own labs for roughly the next two years. Within that period, we will be expanding referral and assay laboratories across the country,” she said.

The number of silver jewellery articles hallmarked rose to 5.9 million in the 2025-26 fiscal year from 3.2 million in 2024-25, according to official data. There are currently around 230 Assaying and Hallmarking Centres recognised by BIS for testing silver jewellery. (PTI)

IIPI organises workshop on cross-border insolvency

The Indian Institute of Insolvency Professionals of ICAI (IIPI) has organised a workshop on cross-border insolvency resolution and model laws.

Experts from the European Union, UK, Singapore, Australia and various entities participated in the workshop, a release said on Sunday.

At the virtual workshop held on Saturday, Anita Shah Akella, joint secretary at the corporate affairs ministry, stressed the importance of designing guidelines for cross-border insolvency, according to a release.

IIPI is promoted by the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI). (PTI)

FMCG firms signal price hikes in Q2 as input cost pressures persist

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rising input costs due to commodity inflation and geopolitical uncertainties are prompting leading FMCG makers to implement calibrated price hikes in the September quarter, as they remain optimistic about demand, citing resilient consumption trends, premiumisation, and improved revenue growth.

The FMCG sector, which took an average hike of

around 2-5 per cent in the June quarter, is going for shrinkflation by reducing the gram-weight or selective pricing actions in the current quarter to protect margins, even as they stay watchful of inflationary pressures, crude

oil volatility and weather-related risks such as the monsoon and El Nino.

Leading bakery food company Britannia said it expects to add another 1.5 to 2 per cent in pricing in the second quarter through “shrinkflation” in its ₹5 and ₹10 biscuit packs, as commodity prices for sugar and palm oil are on the higher side.

Britannia said its Q1 pricing-led growth came mainly from shrinkflation, and expects further pricing actions in the current quarter.

Indian households highly vulnerable to El Niño-driven price shocks: S&P

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Asia-Pacific economies, like India, Vietnam, Indonesia and the Philippines, are seeing a surge in prices, with households remaining highly vulnerable to further weather-related supply shocks, including those triggered by the El Niño, S&P Global Ratings has said.

S&P said the effects of the El Niño period starting in 2026 will reach Asia-Pacific mainly through weaker rainfall and climate disruption, and the macroeconomic impact is likely to be manageable.

Key transmission channels include reduced agricultural output, higher food

inflation, diminished hydropower generation, and vegetation fires and haze.

S&P said many economies have expanded food buffer stocks, improved import planning and strengthened market management mechanisms to cushion supply disruptions. At the same time, investments in reservoir management, irrigation infrastructure and water governance have strengthened resilience to periods of reduced rainfall.

“In India, strong food and grain buffers for affected crops as of July 2026 are key to managing food shock. In addition, authorities are enforcing district-level coordination with farmers to minimise crop losses,” S&P

said in a recent report.

The World Meteorological Organisation (WMO) had last month said that strong El Nino conditions were developing and is expected to strengthen during August through October, bringing powerful weather events around the world.

This could result in above-normal temperatures worldwide.

S&P said South and Southeast Asia are among the more vulnerable regions globally to El Niño. Lower rainfall associated with the climate phenomenon will raise food prices and disrupt water-intensive industries.

GOBARdhan scheme can cut gas imports by \$5B: IBA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian Biogas Association (IBA) on Sunday said it expects a \$5 billion reduction in the gas import bill due to the Government’s ₹23,731-crore GOBARdhan Scheme, a circular bioenergy initiative to convert organic waste like agricultural and cow dung into clean energy.

According to an IBA statement, the recently approved GOBARdhan (Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan) with a financial outlay of ₹23,731 crore should be viewed as a strategic national investment rather than a public expenditure.

Its returns extend well beyond the bioenergy sector, generating measurable economic, environmental and social dividends through import substitution, rural development and improved

agricultural productivity, it stated.

The largest economic payoff will arise from reduced natural gas imports. India imports a significant amount (50 per cent) of its natural gas requirements, which exposes the Indian economy to volatile international prices and geopolitical risks.

In FY 2024-25, the LNG import bill accounted for \$15.2 billion (approximately ₹1.28 lakh crore, assuming an average exchange rate of ₹84/USD), and though the FY25-26 data is not yet published, it is surely a sharp jump over the previous year, owing to the prolonged West Asia crisis and plummeting INR against USD, according to the association.

Even with a conservative estimate of 1500 fully functional CBG plants in the forthcoming years, the trade deficit on account of natural gas import shall be at least diminished by

one-third of its current level, ie \$5 billion (approximately ₹40 lakh crore). Another significant source of payoff is the reduction in fertiliser imports and subsidy burden. CBG facilities produce Fermented Organic Manure (FOM) and liquid bio-slurry rich in essential plant nutrients. Their use supplements chemical fertilisers, particularly imported phosphatic and

potassic fertilisers, while reducing dependence on subsidised urea. It stated that lower fertiliser imports and subsidy requirements translate into significant fiscal savings, making the scheme economically self-reinforcing.

In FY 24-25, the fertiliser import bill accounted for ₹18 billion (approximately ₹1.5 lakh crore). With the estimated 1500 functional CBG plants and adoption of Good Agricultural Practices (optimal blend of synthetic and organic manure), at least 5 per cent of the imports can be reduced, translating into a contribution to the reduction in the Current Account deficit by \$1 billion.

The scheme also delivers significant employment generation opportunities, more particularly in the rural areas, thus stimulating local economies and creating skilled as well as semi-skilled livelihoods.

Govt considering raising CCEA approval threshold for FDI proposals to ₹15,000 cr

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government is considering a proposal to raise the threshold for foreign direct investment proposals requiring approval from the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs to ₹15,000 crore from ₹5,000 crore at present to further improve the country’s investment climate, according to sources.

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) is a high-level committee headed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Its members include key Union Cabinet ministers such as the Home Minister and Finance Minister.

As per the existing foreign direct investment (FDI) policy, in case of proposals involving total foreign equity inflow of more than ₹5,000 crore, the competent authority places the

application for consideration of the CCEA. Below this limit, respective line ministries take a decision.

The existing limit has remained unchanged since November 2015.

Sources said that prevailing economic conditions, inflation, the growing scale of investments over the years, and the objective of promoting ease of doing business necessitate a review of the existing threshold.

US sanctions threaten India’s Russian oil supply, says Kpler

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A US Senate vote to advance tougher sanctions on Russia raises the risk of disruption to Russian crude supplies but is unlikely to immediately alter oil flows to India and China, according to Kpler analyst Sumit Ritolia.

The US Senate on Friday passed a bipartisan Russia sanctions bill that would give President Donald Trump authority to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on imports from countries that are among the world’s largest buyers of Russian oil and gas. The Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia Act of 2026 targets the five biggest purchasers of Russian energy and is aimed at cutting Moscow’s revenues from oil and gas sales.

The measure still needs to clear the US House of Representatives and faces further legislative and administrative steps before it could take effect.

According to Ritolia, the measures still face further legislative and administrative hurdles, while their impact will depend largely on how aggressively the US administration implements them, including whether it grants exemptions or waivers.

“Recent experience suggests that when physical supply security becomes a concern, policymakers retain an incentive to avoid measures that could unnecessarily disrupt crude availability,” he said.

The timing of any curbs is critical as global crude markets remain relatively tight and uncertainty over Middle Eastern supplies has increased the importance of alternative sources, Ritolia said. A significant restriction on Russian oil could therefore tighten global balances rather than simply redirect existing trade flows.

India’s dependence on Russian crude has surged since Russia’s invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, when Western sanctions and an exodus of European buyers left Moscow offering deep discounts to Asian refiners. Russia supplied less than 100,000 barrels per day to India in 2021, or about 2.5 per cent of its crude imports, according to the US Energy Information Administration. The volume rose to about 740,000 bpd in 2022 and nearly 1.8 million bpd in 2023, making Russia India’s largest crude supplier with about 39 per cent of imports that year.

CCI chief calls for sustained cooperation among BRICS competition authorities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Sustained cooperation among BRICS competition authorities will help develop effective, future-ready approaches for competition law enforcement and ensure fair and competitive renewable energy markets, according to CCI Chairperson Ravneet Kaur.

The chairperson made the remarks at the meeting of the heads of the BRICS competition authorities held at Udaipur in Rajasthan on Saturday.

At the meeting, organised by the Competition Commission of India (CCI), the representatives exchanged views on recent developments in competition law and policy in their respective jurisdictions, including significant enforce-

ment initiatives and emerging challenges in their domestic markets, according to a release.

Key findings of a collaborative study on ‘Emerging Competition Landscape in the Renewable Energy Sector in BRICS’ were also presented at the meeting.

In her special address, Kaur highlighted the increasingly cross-border nature of digital markets and emerging technologies.

Sustained cooperation and knowledge-sharing among BRICS competition authorities would be essential for developing informed, effective, and future-ready approaches to competition enforcement, she said.

The CCI chief also emphasised that continued collaboration among BRICS competition authorities would contribute to fostering fair and competitive renewable energy markets while advancing the shared objectives of sustainable growth and energy security, as per the release issued by the regulator.

A joint statement of the heads of the BRICS competition authorities titled ‘Strengthening Cooperation to Promote Fair Competition, including in Renewable Energy Markets’ was adopted at the meeting.

High compliance volume bottlenecks Indian firms: Stakeholders to Par panel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Stakeholders have informed a parliamentary committee that despite multi-phased central deregulation efforts, the absolute volume of business compliances remains a major friction point for domestic enterprises, according to the panel’s report.

According to the department-related parliamentary standing committee on commerce’s report on ‘Doing Business in India: The Way Forward’, stakeholders appraised the panel that while pan-India rationalisation drives have successfully neutralised over 40,000 regulatory obligations, the survival of overlapping rules

continues to inflate fixed operational costs and suppress long-term capital deployment.

“The committee was informed by stakeholders that despite multi-phased central deregulation efforts, the absolute volume of business compliances remains an overbearing friction point for domestic enterprise interface,” it said.

Citing an example, it said a typical firm operating in India currently navigates an archaic and disconnected web of regulations consisting of 1,536 distinct Acts, which collectively impose 69,233 separate compliance requirements and mandate 6,618 independent statutory filings across the three tiers of Government.

The stakeholders have also informed that the Government has enacted the four Labour Codes, which combine 29 central laws and hold the potential to reduce compliance; however, once fully implemented, significant hurdles remain.

“As labour is a concurrent subject, each Central law is accompanied by a range of State-specific legislations, along with both Central and State regulations, adding layers of complexity to the

legal landscape,” it added.

Stakeholders highlighted that due to this slow transition, corporate entities are still structurally bottlenecked by having to concurrently comply with 44 separate Central statutes and more than 100 distinct State-specific Labour laws, each maintaining its own independent reporting cycles, standard registers and manual compliance procedures, the report said.

It also said that fragmented regulations and multiple approvals at the Central and State levels cause “delays and increase the cost of doing business”.

The committee has noted that overlapping compliance requirements lead to duplication of effort.

“The Committee recommends rationalisation and consolidation of regulatory frameworks by adopting risk-based regulations and increasing the use of self-certification and third-party certification,” the report said, adding that during its interactions with various stakeholders, the committee observed that processes for obtaining approvals and issuance of NoCs continue to be time-consuming.

According to the parliamentary panel, despite significant policy and digital reforms, the transportation and logistics sector continues to face regulatory, procedural and infrastructure-related constraints that increase logistics costs and adversely affect the ease of doing business.

EVERY GENERATION GETS ITS OWN BATTLE



RAJESHWAR SINGH

Our grandparents were killed by the water they drank; we are being killed by the air we breathe. The problem changes each generation — what solves it never does. And the first quality any generation needs is gratitude, because none of us reached the starting line unaided. There is a comfort-ing myth that some earlier Indian generation had it easy. Examine any of them and it collapses.

The generation of 1942 faced a problem no textbook could solve: the country was not its own. The generation that inherited freedom was handed an almost empty house — life expectancy of about 32 years, roughly 145 of every 1,000 babies dead before their first birthday, one Indian in eight literate. Imagine graduating into that country at twenty-two, and then building the dams, steel plants, the IITs and AIIMS on small salaries and smaller meals, halving the death rate within two decades.

Those after them got four wars, oil shocks, ration queues and an eight-year wait for a telephone — then 1991, when reserves fell to a few weeks and national gold was pledged abroad. They held the country together and then opened it up; the next generation met global competition and turned what looked like an invasion into the IT boom.

The rule is unbroken: no generation got a soft landing, and none could use its predecessor's toolkit. Satyagraha could not build a steel plant. Nehruvian planning could not survive 1991. The baton has passed again.

The deadline, not the dividend

India has around 367 million young people, the largest youth cohort in history. This is called a demographic dividend; it is more accurately a deadline - the State of Working India 2026 report warns we are nearing its peak while graduate unemployment stays high and job creation lags behind.

The paradox is inverted from 1947. Then the scarce thing was education; today it is the bridge between education and earning. The young are about 83 per cent of India's unemployed, and fewer than seven per cent of male graduates found permanent salaried work within a year of finishing. Between 2014 and 2022, some 22 crore applications chased roughly 7.2 lakh central government posts — three hundred aspirants a seat. And artificial intelligence now presses on the entry point itself: the routine junior work that once taught us our trades is being absorbed by software, so the bottom rung is shaking.

The battle that moved inside the body

Nowhere is the shift clearer than in what Indians die of. The 1947 generation fought an enemy from outside — a mosquito, a contaminated well — and won decisively: smallpox went by 1977, polio by 2014, infant mortality fell from 145 per 1,000 to 27, life expectancy more than doubled.



This generation's enemy does not invade. It is invited. The ICMR-INDIAB study found 101 million Indians living with diabetes and 136 million more pre-diabetic; hypertension affects 315 million. Non-communicable diseases now cause roughly two-thirds of all deaths — the near-exact inverse of 1947 — and they arrive early: in the West about 23 per cent of cardiac deaths occur before seventy; in India, 52 per cent.

Add the wound our grandparents had no word for: 1,71,418 suicides in 2023, some 41 per cent of them under thirty. And the old war is unfinished — a third of Indian children remain stunted in the same country where a third of adult women are obese. They fell ill from what they could not get; we fall ill from what we cannot stop consuming.

The air we cannot boil

But the largest battle is not in the body at all. It is in the environment around it, and it dwarfs the rest, because every other ambition assumes a habitable country to pursue it in. See how completely the terms

have changed. Our grandparents were killed by what they drank: cholera came with every monsoon, and diarrhoeal disease was among the great killers of Indian children. That war has largely been won by plumbing. When the Jal Jeevan Mission began in 2019, only 3.23 crore rural households — 17 per cent — had a tap; by early 2026 it was around 15.8 crore, over 81 per cent, with 2.7 lakh villages certified Har Ghar Jal.

And yet the enemy simply changed medium - from the water we drank to the air we breathe, and there is no equivalent of boiling it. All of India's 1.4 billion citizens breathe air exceeding the WHO's PM2.5 guideline.

The Lancet Countdown puts deaths from man-made particulate pollution at 1.72 million in 2022 alone, costing near 9.5 per cent of GDP, and the Air Quality Life Index calculates it shortens the average Indian life by about 3.5 years — twice the toll of malnutrition and five times that of unsafe water. We are surrendering a portion of the very lifespan

the last generation fought to win. Nor is the water story finished: NITI Aayog warns more than half of India's monitored wells are declining. We have solved distribution while depleting the source.

This is the defining difference. Illness of the body answers to personal discipline. Environmental degradation does not — no individual can boil the air, recharge an aquifer or cool a city alone. It is the first challenge that yields neither to a government programme by itself nor to private virtue by itself. It needs both, sustained for decades, by a generation that will not see the full benefit — exactly what every generation before us managed to do.

The debt that comes before the battle

Before any tactic or principle, something is owed — and it is the single most important quality a generation can possess.

The freedom to write this sentence was bought by people who went to jail for it, and by some who did not come back. The forty additional years the average Indian now lives were paid for by a generation that ate less so dams and hospitals could be built. The literacy that lets a young Indian compete for a global job was often funded by grandparents who could not read a line themselves. That we now worry about obesity rather than famine is a monument to somebody else's hunger.

This is not sentiment but accurate accounting. Every generation begins several kilometres ahead of where the last one started, and nobody arrives at that line by their

own merit. It matters practically too. A generation that believes it invented itself turns brittle: it reads difficulty as injustice and treats those who built the foundations as obstacles rather than elders. A generation that knows what it was handed understands that a hard problem is not a punishment but a continuation. And since our grandparents built for people they would never meet, the debt cannot be settled by thanking them — only by paying it forward.

What has never changed

None of this justifies despair. Employability has risen nearly ten points in four years, and India holds roughly 16 per cent of the world's AI talent. The average path is getting harder while the prepared path is getting better - which side a young Indian lands on is, uncomfortably often, a choice rather than a fate.

Beneath every tactic sit five qualities that have outlived every transition

Gratitude, first and largest, because it orders all the others. It converts entitlement into obligation, resentment into resolve, inheritance into stewardship. A person without it works only for himself — and stops working the moment it stops paying.

Hard work. Angela Duckworth's West Point studies found a cadet's grit predicted survival through the harshest training better than intelligence, leadership rating or fitness. Talent is common; persistence is rare, and outlasts it.

Character. Where competent work can be generated on demand, trustworthiness

becomes the scarcest thing in the market. Skill opens the door; character decides whether you are invited back.

Focus. In an age engineered to fragment attention, holding one hard problem for one uninterrupted hour is close to a competitive advantage — precisely because it has become rare.

Faith. Karmanye vadhikaraste — the right is to the action, never to its fruit. Faith steadies a person through the interval between work and result, and stops success curdling into arrogance.

The generation of 1947 did not know India would survive as a democracy; the reformers of 1991 did not know their gamble would pay. They worked in the dark with clean hands, and history was written behind them rather than in front of them. Everything we argue about today — the jobs, the machines, the air itself — we argue about standing on ground they cleared. No generation is consulted about the difficulty of its challenge. It is asked only what it intends to do about it — and whether it was worth what the last one paid.

Sources: Azim Premji University, State of Working India 2026; ILO-IHD India Employment Report; ICMR-INDIAB (Lancet Diabetes & Endocrinology, 2023); NFHS-6 (2023-24); NCRB; Lancet Countdown (2025); Air Quality Life Index (2025); Jal Jeevan Mission data (2026); NITI Aayog; Duckworth et al. (2007).

The writer is an MLA from Sarojini Nagar, Lucknow and former Joint Director of Enforcement Directorate

Shikha's Kariigarii opens Saree Shastra at India International Centre

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Shikha's Kariigarii, a woman-led social enterprise working with over 100 artists and artisans across India, has opened an exhibition titled Saree Shastra at the India International Centre (IIC) in New Delhi.

The exhibition is built around a central provocation: a single length of cloth suspended at the centre of a ring of spears, a mace, and knives, asking visitors whether the saree, which outlasts rather than conquers, is itself a form of power.

The exhibition is curated across several interconnected sections, each building on the opening installation's argument. The first confronts



visitors with the weapons before they encounter the cloth. The second places a Sanskrit verse at its centre, describing how where women are honoured, the divine flourishes, surrounding it with representations of the many roles women inhabit simultaneously: lawyer, artist, politician, singer, sportsper-son, homemaker, and care-giver, moving between these

without fully setting any one down.

The third section turns the saree into a canvas. Pichwai, Pattachitra, Gond, Warli, Aipan, and Sohrai art from different regions of India sit alongside contemporary work. Hand-painted sarees hang next to handwoven and embroidered ones, includ-ing GI-verified weaves from across the country. The

section is designed to feel like an art gallery where every work on the wall can also be folded up and worn home.

The fourth section puts the makers in full view. Two Pichwai artists from Rajasthan are present at the exhibition, hand-painting fabric while explaining the nuances of the form to visitors. A contemporary artist works with carved blocks, painting post-cards that visitors take home. The presence of working artists is intentional: the exhibition's argument is that her-itage survives only where it is practised, shared, and watched as it is made.

The fifth section turns to history. The exhibition traces how handloom weaving was hollowed out by colonial mills and the flood of British-

manufactured textiles, and how, during the Swadeshi Movement of 1905, words and symbols began appear-ing within woven borders and pallus, turning hand-loom weaving into an instru-ment of resistance and national consciousness.

A programme of panel dis-cussions accompanies the exhibition on the theme of saree as a living civilisation-al legacy, covering art, her-itage, identity, and women's narratives. Speakers include Dr Karan Singh, IAS officers Mugdha Sinha and Bandana Preyashi, former Textile Secretary Rita Menon, Dr Sanjay Kumar Manjul of the Archaeological Survey of India, and Dr Promil Pande, Dean of the School of Design at GD Goenka University.

Central Bank of India celebrates birthday of its founding father

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Bank of India Zonal office in Delhi celebrates the 145th birthday of its founding father, Sorabji Pochkhanwala, by organising a plantation drive with great enthusiasm and commitment towards the environment and society.

As part of the celebration, Zonal Head Tarsem Singh Zira, Deputy Zonal Head TC Meena and other staff members participated in a tree plantation drive under the *Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam* initiative, reaffirming our collective responsibility towards environmental conservation



and a greener future. The occasion was also marked by taking a pledge for the Nasha Mukht Bharat

Abhiyan, demonstrating our commitment towards building a healthy, responsible and drug-free society.

DAILY SUDOKU

						4	7	9
	8			2				
	4	6	9	3				
	9	7	6			8	3	
	2	1			8	7	9	
					6	5	3	4
			7					8
5	1	3						

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

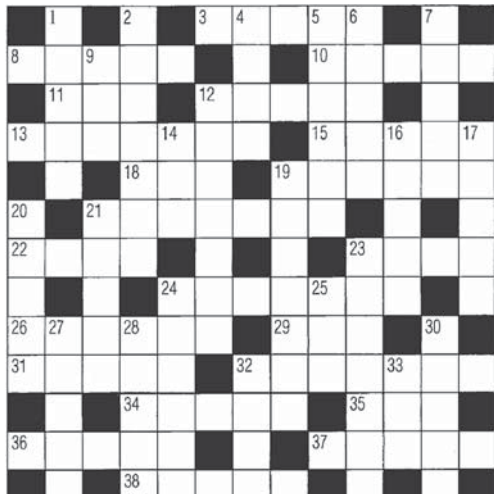


SOLUTION (8.8.26)

6	5	1	3	8	4	7	2	9
2	8	3	5	7	9	4	1	6
7	4	9	2	1	6	3	5	8
4	3	5	7	9	1	6	8	2
8	9	2	6	3	5	1	7	4
1	6	7	8	4	2	9	3	5
3	2	4	1	6	8	5	9	7
9	1	8	4	5	7	2	6	3
5	7	6	9	2	3	8	4	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

MONDAY | AUGUST 10, 2026



ACROSS

- 3 Large box capable of expansion (5)
- 8 Could it describe a quarter of tongue? (5)
- 10 Something noteworthy to sit down and play (5)
- 11 Mountain pass in Monaco, likely enough
- 12 Land of lacquer (5)
- 13 As a work of art, would be said to be incisive (7)
- 15 Heavy reading? (5)
- 18 The odd drink (3)
- 19 Lying in order to obtain treats (2,4)
- 21 Irascible but not tasteless (7)
- 22 Top in the administrative department
- 23 In bed, a pretty little thing (4)

DOWN

- 1 He took a taxi back and forth (5)
- 2 She's no rabid leftist! (7)
- 4 Passion of a theatrical nature (4)
- 5 It's silly to put a cat where a pig ought to be (6)
- 6 Singer of only one sound note? (5)
- 7 Sadness at Chelsea (5)
- 9 Excessively, as it seems to Oscar (3)
- 12 Garments for show in a horsy world? (7)
- 14 Recuperative drink? (3)
- 16 Confusion of combatants (5)
- 17 Brown maybe, but there's one in Scarlet

- 24 It's touchingly read (7)
- 26 Dodges work so as to figure in celestial spheres? (6)
- 29 Compete to get a girl for a sweetheart
- 31 Being very close, he may move to Reims (5)
- 32 Location, near Hackney, of Gladstone's change of heart (7)
- 34 An orange is a non-starter with minced veal! (5)
- 35 Pitiable as some narcotics addicts (3)
- 36 Are such friends apt to be drunk? (5)
- 37 Revolving fellow's late start after swilling beer (5)
- 38 Pass as new verse (5)

- 19 The advent of a hard-hearted competitor (7)
- 20 In outer Clapham, there needs to be an open space (5)
- 21 Where dad's on the right island (in the Seine?) (5)
- 23 Euphemistically cursed! (7)
- 24 To live, to judge, and to scold (6)
- 25 She matches up (3)
- 27 Is she too young to be catty? (5)
- 28 One imagines she's out of this world (5)
- 30 She has just the figure for fashion (5)
- 32 It fuels some of the older vehicles (4)
- 33 Plane spotters may see one on the wing

Kotak Mahindra Bank launches hybrid home loan



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To provide greater certainty on EMIs, Kotak Mahindra Bank has announced the launch of its hybrid home loan, enabling customers to lock their home loan rate for up to 65 months and plan these important early years with greater visibility.

Buying a home is only the beginning of a customer's financial journey, and in initial days, families often manage interiors, education, savings and everyday expenses, alongside the monthly EMI, Kotak Mahindra Bank said in a statement on Sunday.

The product allows customers to choose a fixed-rate period of 39, 52 or 65 months, during which their interest rate and EMI remain unchanged even if the repo rate changes, it said. Presently, Kotak Mahindra Bank is offering housing loans starting at 7.6 per cent.

This gives them a defined window in which to plan household and life expenses, it said, adding that after the selected period, the loan automatically moves to a floating-rate structure linked to the Repo Rate plus a predefined spread disclosed at sanction.

PNB to roll out its wealth management product by December: Ashok Chandra

KUMAR DIPANKAR
■ New Delhi

To enhance its non-interest income, Punjab National Bank (PNB) is planning to roll out wealth management services by December, the bank's managing director and CEO Ashok Chandra said.

"The first stage of our wealth management strategy is to ensure that the bank has Customer Relationship Managers (CRMs) in place. Six months ago, we deployed around 1,700 CRMs across 1,700 branches. Their primary KRA (key responsibility area) is to manage and take care of approximately 250 to 300 top customers in each branch," he told PTI in an interview.

The public sector lender is now planning to deploy another 1,300 CRMs and by end of this month. It would deploy them in another identified 1,300 branches.

"That was the first step we undertook. We have also started engaging with consultants for our wealth management initiative. Very shortly, we expect to initiate the RFP process to appoint a partner for wealth management services."



Ashok Chandra

"I believe that within the next three to four months, our wealth management offering will also be in place. Going forward, PNB will have a very active engagement in providing wealth management services," he said.

Asked about the launch of this offering, he said, "We expect to roll it out by the third quarter."

Speaking about its credit card business, Chandra said, the bank working on expanding its business which it is operating as a division headed by a General Manager.

"As of March 31, 2025, the bank had only around 6.6 lakh credit card holders. However, we saw significant potential in the credit card business and decided to scale up the business. The first step was to create a comprehensive roadmap supported by a digital stack. It took us around five months to build the digital infrastructure," he said.

Once the digital structure was in place in November 2025, the bank started scaling up the business aggressively, he said, adding, PNB also launched a premium, high-net-worth metal credit card called the Luxura Credit Card, which has generated significant traction in the overall credit card market.

"By the end of March 2026, we had around 9 lakh credit card holders, and today we are approaching 10 lakh. This year, we expect to cross 15 lakh credit card holders. We are already approaching the 25,000 mark for our high-net-worth Luxura Credit Card. We launched it just four months ago, and we have already reached around 25,000 card-holders," he said.

The bank has introduced a number of facilities and benefits through the metal card and expects cardholder numbers to touch 1 lakh by the end of the ongoing financial year. (PTI)

Press Note

Date: 08/08/2026

Ujjain Municipal Corporation

Expression of Interest

Tender No-2026_UAD_527917_1

Ujjain Municipal Corporation invites EOI from Banks, Financial Institutions, NBFCs, and other eligible entities for a long-term loan of ₹200 Cr for financing the purchase, transfer, utilisation and redevelopment of Transferable Development Rights (TDR)

The detailed EOI can be downloaded from <https://mptenders.gov.in/> and bids must be submitted online by 22/08/2026 (6 PM).

Additional Commissioner (Finance)

Ujjain Municipal Corporation

BRIEFLY

Sanya Vats finishes runner-up in Ballarat Open squash



India's Sanya Vats finished runner-up at the Ballarat Open squash, a USD 3000 PSA Challenger event in Victoria, Australia on Sunday. The second seed Indian went down 6-11, 8-11, 6-11 to top seed and local favourite Sarah Cardwell in the women's final. The Delhi girl earlier beat South Korean Ain Jun 11-5, 11-8, 11-4 in the semifinals after defeating another South Korean Sunghye Oh 6-11, 11-9, 12-10, 11-4 in the quarterfinals. (PTI)

Search on for Nitin Patel's replacement: VVS Laxman

The BCCI Centre of Excellence chief VVS Laxman on Sunday said the hunt for a suitable candidate to fill the role of Head of Sports Science and Medicine at the facility is still on despite Nitin Patel quitting the post almost 18 months ago. In this interim, Dhananjay Kaushik, the senior physiotherapist, is handling the job at the CoE.

But the extended time to find a replacement for Patel is staggering because of the mounting injury cases among Indian cricketers. However, Laxman said the delay is not due to BCCI's indifference. "We are divided into four verticals. After Nitin left, we did not get anyone who can fill in that position. We had Andrew Leipus, and everything was agreed upon. In fact, (BCCI secretary) Devajit (Saikia) had two or three meetings with him but suddenly Andrew backed off citing family reasons," Laxman told select media at the BCCI CoE. Laxman said moving to Bengaluru, where the CoE is based, was one of the mandatory criteria for the candidates who applied for the post. "We conducted a full fledged interview process where we had Dr. Dinshaw Pardiwala, Dr Ashish Soni, Dr Rohan Khavte and myself, and we shortlisted five candidates and number one was an Australian. After selecting him, suddenly he also backed out saying he cannot move to Bangalore and it was one of the important conditions. "It is a full time job and it is not a part time one. It is day to day monitoring. That professional did not join. Another professional was the head of sports science at All Blacks (New Zealand rugby team) and we engaged with him and he almost agreed but at the last moment he also backed off." However, the 51-year-old said the current staff at CoE has stepped up in an excellent manner. "To fill in the position, you require not someone of the stature but the knowledge and understanding of Indian cricketers. But I think a lot of credit goes to the professionals who are already in the team because they have stepped up." Laxman said they will be filling in the role at the earliest. "So, I think the lookout is there, and you have to find someone who is qualified and capable enough to take up that position. So we will quite definitely fill that position and the suitable candidate has to be identified," he added. Amidst this news emerged that certain cricketers like Nitish Kumar Reddy opted to train with individual coaches in an effort to bump up his pace. Reddy is also recuperating at the CoE after suffering a hamstring injury. "And I think there's a lot of news which is happening. But as I said, the way we do it is the Indian team, S&C, is responsible for keeping a track of the contracted players. (PTI)



India's hockey WC journey: From 1971 to 2023

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ New Delhi

India's men's hockey team has had a roller-coaster journey in the World Cup, from winning the inaugural bronze in 1971 to lifting the title in 1975 and then enduring a long wait for another podium finish.

The eight-time Olympic champions' only World Cup triumph came in Kuala Lumpur in 1975, when Ajit Pal Singh's side defeated arch-rivals Pakistan 2-1 in the final.

1971 Barcelona: The World Cup was conceived after India and Pakistan jointly proposed a hockey tournament on the lines of football's World Cup at the FIH Council meeting in 1969. Pakistan were initially awarded the hosting rights, but political tensions between the two countries forced the inaugural edition to be

shifted to Barcelona.

1973 Amsterdam: India reached the final of the second World Cup in Amsterdam but missed out on the title after a dramatic finish against hosts the Netherlands. The Indian team finished second in Pool A behind West Germany before beating Pakistan in the semi-finals, with B P Govinda scoring the decisive goal.

1975 Kuala Lumpur: March 15, 1975 remains the defining date in Indian hockey's World Cup history. Led by Ajit Pal Singh, India defeated Pakistan 2-1 in the final to win their only World Cup title so far. Pakistan took the lead, but Surjit Singh equalised in the 44th minute before Ashok Kumar scored the winner in the 51st minute.

1978 Buenos Aires : India's title defence ended in disappointment as the defending champions failed to



qualify for the semi-finals and finished sixth. India won three of their six pool matches but suffered two defeats, including a heavy 0-7 loss to West Germany.

1982 Mumbai : India hosted the World Cup for the first time in Mumbai but could not make it to the final four, finishing fifth. Pakistan remained unbeaten and defeated

West Germany 3-1 in the final at the Wankhede Stadium to win their third World Cup title.

1986 London : India endured their worst World Cup campaign to that point, finishing 12th and last in London.

1990 Lahore: The World Cup in Lahore was played amid political tensions, hostile home crowd and heightened security concerns.

1994 Sydney: Under captain Jude Felix, India finished fifth in Sydney, their best World Cup result on artificial turf at that stage.

1998 Utrecht: European teams dominated the tournament in Utrecht, with hosts the Netherlands defeating Spain in the final to claim their third World Cup title.

2002 Kuala Lumpur: The 2002 edition marked the introduction of the 16-team World Cup format.

2006 Monchengladbach: India endured another difficult campaign under captain Dilip Tirkey, failing to win a single match in the pool stage.

2010 Delhi: India's biggest highlight at the 2010 World Cup on home soil came in the pool stage when they thrashed arch-rivals Pakistan 4-1 before a packed Major Dhyan Chand National Stadium.

2014 The Hague: India endured a disappointing campaign in The Hague, suffering heavy defeats to Belgium, England and Australia and finishing ninth in the pool stage.

2018 Bhubaneswar: India hosted the World Cup in Odisha, the hockey heartland of the country, for the first time.

2023 Bhubaneswar-Rourkela: India hosted the World Cup for the second successive time and again finished second in their pool. (PTI)

Morocco earn Women's World Cup berth with 2-1 WAFCON quarterfinal victory over South Africa

STEVE MEGARGEE
■ Rabat (Morocco)

Sakina Ouzraoui and Hanane Ait El Haj both scored and Morocco earned a spot in next summer's Women's World Cup with a 2-1 victory over South Africa in the quarterfinals of the Women's Africa Cup of Nations on Saturday.

Morocco will face the winner of Sunday's quarterfinal between Nigeria and Cameroon in a semifinal match on Wednesday.

Thembi Kgatlana scored the lone goal for South Africa in the 67th minute. She had an earlier chance in the 22nd



minute but her shot was just off target.

Morocco took the lead in the 32nd minute when Ouzraoui volleyed a shot over South Africa goalkeeper Kaylin Swart. Morocco

gave Morocco a 2-0 lead. Kgatlana closed the gap for South Africa with a goal that was awarded following a lengthy video review after she was initially ruled to be offside. Kgatlana has nine goals in WAFCON appearances since her tournament debut for South Africa in 2018. It will be Morocco's second appearance in the World Cup. The team advanced to round of 16 at the 2023 tournament. South Africa still has a chance to qualify for the World Cup. The losing quarterfinal teams play on Thursday for a spot in an intercontinental playoff. (AP)

Hossler and Brennan share Wyndham title lead

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Greensboro (USA)

Beau Hossler handled a half-dozen tough par putts and two rain delays Saturday for a 4-under 66 that gave him a share of the lead with Michael Brennan going into the final round of the Wyndham Championship with postseason berths at stake.

Hossler is No. 122 in the FedEx Cup, knowing his only mathematical chance to be among the top 70 to advance to playoffs is to win for the first time on the PGA Tour.

Brennan, who went from the PGA Tour Americas to a PGA Tour card by winning the Bank of Utah Championship last fall, made a birdie putt from 15 feet on the last hole for a 63.

They were at 16-under 194,

one shot ahead of Scottish Open winner Tom Kim (63), and two shots clear of 44-year-old Alex Noren and Alex Smalley, who each shot 65.

Such is the nature of the final regular-season tournament - and the stakes - that nine of the top 10 players on the leaderboard shot 66 or lower on Saturday.

Hossler was leading until a 30-minute delay because of storms, and returned to three-putt from 30 feet for bogey on the par-3 16th hole, ending his streak of 31 holes without a bogey. He hit his tee shot into the rough on the 17th and then came another delay of 1 hour, 20 minutes. The rough was even thicker and damper when he returned, and the greens were challenging as ever. Hossler save par with



three putts from 10 feet or long, and three others in the 5-foot range that looks even longer with the grain in the greens.

"That might be the hardest two-putt on the PGA Tour right there," Hossler said of the 18th green. "Was really glad to get that down in two and give myself a chance for

tomorrow. But very chaotic day, and just glad to make it through." Jordan Smith of England, at No. 68 in the FedEx Cup, helped his cause in many ways when he made a hole-in-one on the par-3 16th hole with a 9-iron. That also came with a million reward points from tournament sponsor Wyndham.

Ashmita Chaliha stuns Han to win maiden BWF Tour title at Korea Masters

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Asan (Korea)

India's Ashmita Chaliha produced a gritty show to secure her maiden BWF World Tour title with a fighting win over fourth seed Han Qian Xi of China in the women's singles final of the Korea Masters Super 300 badminton tournament here on Sunday.

The 26-year-old from Assam, who had suffered a career-threatening knee injury two years back in Korea, overcame a slow start and a testing decider to complete a memorable victory, recovering from the loss of the opening game to stun world No. 35 Han 14-21, 21-14, 21-14 in the summit clash that lasted 53 minutes.

"I feel really great and

unbelievable. But then I am trying to digest it. Now, I am hungry for more," said Ashmita, who trains under Park Tae-Sang at the National Centre of Excellence in Guwahati.

"In the first game, it was a little bit tricky because of the drift conditions, so I was not able to manage it... But in the second, the other side was more comfortable and there was less drift, so I was able to control it. And in the third, after 11 points, I changed again, so I was on the good side. I'm glad that I could pull off."

Ashmita's win marks back-to-back BWF World Tour finals for Indians, with Tanvi Sharma having won the Taipei Open last Sunday.

Park, who has now seen



two of his wards win Super 300 titles in successive weeks, believes Ashmita always had the tools to succeed but needed to become more consistent in her approach.

"Before the injury, Ashmita was already a good player and a very good talent. She has a good smash and nice

movement, but unfortunately, at the wrong time, she had to take a break because of the injury," the South Korean told PTI. "When she joined me, I thought, 'Oh, she is a good player.' But tactically and strategically, and also a little bit mentally, she had some problems." The world

number 50 Ashmita had to undergo surgery and an extensive rehabilitation period after suffering a medial meniscus tear in her right knee during the Korea Open in 2024. She returned in February next year and played 14 events. This year she competed in a couple of events but then spent three months building strength to handle a full elite BWF calendar load. She enjoyed a strong comeback on the BWF Tour with back-to-back quarterfinals at China Masters and Malaysia Masters and then a semifinal appearance at the Macau Open. Ahead of Sunday's final, Park and Ashmita analysed Han's game on video, with the coach identifying unforced errors as the biggest obstacle.

"Yesterday, we also did a video analysis of her Chinese opponent. I told Ashmita, 'Your biggest problem is your own mistakes. You are making simple mistakes. But if you can reduce those simple mistakes, 100 per cent, I promise you, you can win the title today,'" Park said.

In the final, Ashmita opened up a 3-0 start and had a 9-5 lead early on but Han made a stirring comeback as the two players were locked at 11-11. The Chinese shuttler found another gear and a run of points helped her establish control as she closed out the game comfortably to earn the bragging rights.

Ashmita responded strongly in the second game. She attacked with greater authority, using her smashes to put

Han under pressure while also producing some sharp defensive returns to break off aft 6-6. The Indian led 11-8 at the interval and continued to dictate the rallies thereafter.

Han struggled to close the gap as Ashmita maintained a comfortable advantage, moving 17-10 ahead before wrapping up the game 21-14 with another powerful attacking shot to force a decider. The final game was closely fought early on, with Ashmita moving to a 5-2 lead early on only to see Han edge ahead 11-9 at the mid-game break.

Ashmita, however, kept fighting and gradually turned the momentum in her favour. She moved ahead 12-11 with a precise winner along the line. Another exceptional

shot, played while stretching low towards the shuttle, landed just inside the court as Chaliha extended her advantage to 15-11. The Indian continued to find the gaps in Han's court and a cross-court winner made it 19-14. Han then sent her return wide, handing Ashmita the championship point and, ultimately, her first BWF World Tour title. "In the first game, she played well. But in the second game, again, she started making easy mistakes. When the second game finished, I told her, 'Ashmita, think about the first game and think about the second game. What was the difference?' The reason was very simple. In the second game, you made too many mistakes," Park said.

FIFA defends Infantino against allegations tied to his time at UEFA

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

FIFA has issued a statement defending its president, Gianni Infantino, against what it calls a "concerted and ongoing effort" to undermine his leadership of the organisation.

The statement was released Saturday, a day after a report by British newspaper The Daily Telegraph raising questions about an exit package paid by UEFA to a female staffer who worked with Infantino when he was general secretary of European soccer's governing body. UEFA confirmed that a "departure payment" was made to the employee and said it was "in



line" with regulations at the time. Infantino worked at UEFA for 16 years before being elected FIFA president.

In the statement Saturday, FIFA accused Infantino's critics of trying to weaken his authority and remove him from office without due process. "It is increasingly

evident that there is a concerted and ongoing effort by some to undermine FIFA and its president," the FIFA statement said. "Those who do not have the support of FIFA's member associations should not seek to achieve through allegation, insinuation or misinformation what they

cannot achieve through FIFA's established democratic processes." It said some reporting has included "unsubstantiated assertions and demonstrably false claims" which shouldn't be presented as fact.

"Change inevitably challenges established interests, but disagreement with that change cannot justify efforts to undermine the democratic mandate of FIFA's president or the institution he was elected to lead."

Infantino faced intense backlash after details of his plan to sell World Cup profits to private equity were published. UEFA and two other continental confederations - North America's CONCACAF

and the Asian Football Confederation - rejected the plan. He did receive backing from FIFA's management board last Wednesday following a meeting in Morocco, and he apologized over the process. UEFA's threat to have its 55 member countries boycott FIFA competitions until the plan was scrapped remained, with UEFA saying Thursday that the announcement "changes nothing."

While confirming the exit payment "was in line with the regulations that existed for departing staff at the time," UEFA said the rules had been tightened since 2016 and currently "reflect those found in a modern, high-profile organization."

TRAU FC edge Indian Navy to end campaign on a high

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Imphal

Afridi Buyamayum scored twice, including a spectacular second-half strike, as TRAU FC secured a hard-fought 2-1 victory over Indian Navy FT in their final Group D fixture of the Durand Cup on Sunday.

Despite being dominated for large periods and facing relentless pressure from Indian Navy, who registered a staggering 26 attempts on goal, TRAU FC produced a clinical display in front of goal. Buyamayum's brace (16' and 60') and an inspired



performance from goalkeeper Tajuddin helped the Manipur side hold on for all three points.

Buyamayum opened the scoring in the 16th minute before Indian Navy responded immediately after half-

time through Khullakpam Zahir Khan (46'). However, Buyamayum restored TRAU's advantage in the 60th minute with a stunning strike to put his side back in front. The result saw TRAU FC finish second in Group D with four points from their three matches.

Indian Navy also ended their group stage campaign with three points from three matches, with both sides bowing out before the quarter-finals. The result also confirmed debutants FC Raengdai as Group D winners, securing their place in the quarter-finals.

Gill shine as India beat SL in warm-up match

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Yashasvi Jaiswal and Shubman Gill struck useful runs at the top of the order before Mohammed Siraj's late blitz helped India beat Sri Lanka Cricket XI by six wickets in their three-day warm-up game here on Sunday. Chasing 207 for victory, India completed the target in 45 overs, finishing on 214 for four with Siraj smashing 32 off just 15 balls, including three successive sixes, to bring game to emphatic end.

Jaiswal, who had fallen for a duck in India's first innings, responded in style with a quickfire 61 off 46 balls. He and Gill put on exactly 105 for the opening wicket to give India a



flying start to their chase. Jaiswal retired after reaching his half-century to allow his teammates valuable time in the middle.

Gill, returning to action after

missing the first two days of the fixture with a finger injury, made a useful 44 before being dismissed by spinner Keshara Niswantha. His return to the middle was a significant pos-

itive for India ahead of the opening Test against Sri Lanka. Dhruv Jurel chipped in with 17, while Rishabh Pant made a patient 28 before India were briefly reduced to 155 for three.

But the target was never in serious danger, with the lower order completing the chase in the final session. Siraj then provided the fireworks, hitting three consecutive sixes to finish the game in style. Earlier, Sri Lanka Cricket XI declared their second innings at 200 for six in 45 overs, leaving India a target of 207.

Opener Nishan Madushka, who had also scored a half-century in the first innings, top-scored with 63 off 73 balls, while Nipun Dhananjaya made 46 and Anjala Bandara

contributed 35. Ravindra Jadeja and Gurnoor Brar claimed two wickets each for India, while Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh Krishna took one apiece.

India had earlier declared their first innings at 357 for six after Sri Lanka XI posted 363 for eight declared.

Devdutt Padikkal was the star of India's first-innings effort with an unbeaten 142, while Jadeja scored 63 and Manav Suthar contributed 41. Gurnoor Brar remained unbeaten on 36 as India finished just six runs behind the hosts. The warm-up game provided India with useful match practice ahead of the two-Test series against Sri Lanka, with the first match scheduled to begin in Galle on August 15.

PM Modi meets CWG medallists, lauds their performances

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday met members of the Indian contingent that returned with medals from the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow and congratulated the athletes for their impressive performances at the multi-sport event.

Modi shared a short video clip of his interaction with the medallists on Instagram, describing the meeting as a special occasion and praising the athletes for making the country proud. Among those who interacted with



the prime minister was boxer Sakshi Chaudhary, who won the gold medal in the women's 51kg category at the Games. India enjoyed a strong campaign in Glasgow, finishing with 39 medals, including 13 gold.

Sakshi, said: "Our honourable PM sir has welcomed all the medallists from the Commonwealth Games and we are feeling very proud of this. We have really enjoyed meeting him, he is very humble."

'Players not machines, co-ordination between CoE, management great'

G UNNIKRIISHNAN ■ Bengaluru

Putting up a stout defence of BCCI's Centre of Excellence, its chief VVS Laxman on Sunday said the center should not be blamed for slow recovery of players as cricketers are not "machines" who meet recuperation timelines every time.

Laxman asserted that there is "seamless" coordination between CoE and team management. Strike bowler Jasprit Bumrah, all-rounders Harshit Rana, Hardik Pandya, Washington Sundar and top-order batter B Sai Sudharsan are some of the players who have been recuperating from their respective injuries at the CoE at present.

"See, CoE is not just a rehab centre, but there are bigger roles to play for it in helping cricketers achieve excellence. So, we don't like to use the term 'blame' (for injuries) because when

you're using that term, then you're finding someone as a scapegoat," Laxman told select media at the CoE.

"But there's brilliant coordination between the CoE and the team management of both the teams (men and women) and the SSM staff of both the teams. So that communication is happening seamlessly," Laxman said given the stringent fitness parameters and nature of the human body, it's tough for a player to attain full fitness at a specific timeline.

"This is where I think it's very important to understand that the guidelines and the timelines are given based on what you expect. But it's the human body. It is not a machine where the timelines will always be met.

"So there's a continuous process of understanding how a player is progressing and based on that, the load is increased. So that's a



process from the time they are diagnosed with the injury to the time they leave the CoE and declare fit," he explained. Laxman put his finger on the cases of Bumrah and Sudharsan to explain his point. "Now you're talking about Bumrah and Sai Sudarshan. The process is that the selector reaches out to the CoE asking for the fitness status report and we collect it and send it to the selection committee chairman or chairperson in women's selection commit-

tee with a copy to the head coach of both the teams and the BCCI. "Now Bumrah and Sudarshan, there's always an asterisk against their name. It means subject to fitness. So Bumrah and Sudarshan were going to be picked for Sri Lanka subject to fitness clearance.

"As I told before, we assess them, move them from one stage to the next stage and if the progression is slow, you communicate to the selection committee chairman and the head coach, which is

happening seamlessly, and they understand that they're not yet ready to participate in an international series," he detailed. But isn't it a massive concern to see a large pool of players getting consistently injured?

The former Indian cricketer downplayed the sequence and said injuries are part and parcel of a player's career. "I don't think it's a cause of concern. But obviously, when someone is playing at the elite level, you're supposed to give more than 100%." "So I think ultimately, injuries are part and parcel of any player. So, if you're thinking about not getting injured, then you're not playing to the best of your ability," he said.

The 51-year-old said the way outside world see injuries to players should be changed. "So I think one thing which should be addressed and I think that's

changed dramatically is how you see injury. Do you see injury as a negative thing?

Or do you think injury is part and parcel? "I think that's why the monitoring system is very critical. And I've got no doubt that Adrian and Nick or Kamlesh (fitness staff at the BCCI CoE) are doing that," he noted. So, how do they arrive at the decision to release a player after rehabilitation from a specific injury? "We have set certain parameters with the SSM and S&C process.

Until and unless those benchmarks are not met, or in fact got better, we don't release (the players). "The whole idea is that when he goes back to the Indian team, men and women, or wherever, including the state teams or whatever teams he is participating, from the first match, he should be able to perform to the best of his potential." (PTI)

Kuldeep took break to assess body: Bahutule

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Kuldeep Yadav did not bowl in the second innings of the warm-up game against Sri Lanka Cricket XI as he wanted to assess his body after a heavy workload, India's spin bowling coach Sairaj Bahutule said, allaying concerns over left-arm wrist-spinner's fitness.

Kuldeep bowled 18 overs in the three-day game after also putting in two-three overs before the match, and Bahutule said the decision to



rest him was purely precautionary. "Kuldeep bowled almost 20 overs in the sense 18 in the match and about two-three overs before the game also. He had a very good outing and he just wanted to take a break in terms of just understanding how his body is at," Bahutule said.

Sai Sudharsan ruled out; Sarfaraz named replacement for Test series against Sri Lanka

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Mumbai batter Sarfaraz Khan on Sunday replaced injured Sai Sudharsan in the Indian squad for the Test series against Sri Lanka, starting August 15.

The left-handed Sudarshan had suffered a toe injury during the India A tour last month and is recovering at the BCCI Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Bengaluru.

The BCCI said Sudarshan



has made significant progress in his recovery and



its medical team is closely monitoring his progress.

"The men's Selection Committee has named Sarfaraz Khan as a replacement for Sai Sudharsan for the two-match Test series against Sri Lanka," BCCI said in a release.

"He will link up with the Indian squad in Colombo before the team travels to Galle for the first Test match, starting August 15, 2026."

The 28-year-old Sarfaraz has played six Tests for India, his last being a game against New Zealand in Mumbai in 2024.

From Olympic bronze with Sindhu to back-to-back Super 300s

AMIT KUMAR DAS
■ New Delhi

Two Super 300 titles. Two different players. Two consecutive weeks. For Park Tae-Sang, it is not just a fortnight of good results. It offers a glimpse of his work that he has been putting in Indian badminton, building players who, he hopes, can become the next generation of Indian stars.

Last Sunday, 17-year-old Tanvi Sharma won the Taipei Open. Seven days later, 26-year-old Ashmita Chaliha made a stunning comeback from a career-threatening knee injury to win the Korea Masters. "It's been an amazing two weeks. Last week, Tanvi was also amazing. She is only 17 and won her first BWF-level

title. Today, I was even happier because it was Ashmita's first final and she won the title. As a coach, I'm really happy," Park told PTI from Asan, Korea.

Park spent four years with PV Sindhu in Hyderabad, a stint that culminated in the Tokyo Olympics bronze medal. After that association ended, he was approached by the Badminton Association of India about working with younger players.

"When I started working with Sindhu, she was already a world champion and had a group of good senior players around her. This time, I thought to myself, 'Okay, let's start from the beginning. I will build these players myself, with my own hands.



"The idea was to create a new generation of Indian players." Bigger goal is Olympic qualifying race for 2028 LA Games

Three years in National Centre of Excellence, Guwahati and the results are

beginning to show. However, Park sees the two titles as stepping stones to bigger achievements.

"I think winning two BWF 300-level titles in the last two weeks is a good achieve-

ment, but they are only 300-level tournaments. The players are now looking towards the 500, 750 and 1000-level tournaments," he said. "Our bigger goal is the same for both Tanvi and Ashmita. From May 1 next year, the Olympic qualifying race for the 2028 Los Angeles Games will begin, so next year is going to be very important. "We will start playing more 500-level tournaments, and they can also play 750-level tournaments. After today's result, Ashmita's world ranking should improve enough for her to enter some of those tournaments." For Tanvi and Ashmita to genuinely challenge for an Olympic place, it's a tough road ahead. (PTI)

Diksha stays in top-20 at London Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

Diksha Dagar stayed inside the top-20 at the London Championship after a steady 1-over 72 in the third round, keeping alive her hopes of gaining further ground on the Ladies European Tour Order of Merit.

Diksha had 75-70 in the first two rounds and was T-22 but fell to T-19 with a 72 in the third, while Aditi Ashok after 71-73 was T-16 and she also fell to T-19 with a 73 at Centurion Club.

Pranavi Urs with 71-72 had risen to T-12, but she fell dramatically to T-38 after a card



of 78 on the third day of the USD two million event.

Diksha can move up further in the Order of Merit with a good finish.

Canada's Anna Huang fired the round of the day

with a bogey-free 65 (-8) to lead a score of 19-under-par after 54 holes.

The three-time Ladies European Tour (LET) winner has led from the first round and began with a birdie at the first before adding another birdie on the fourth hole. England's Charley Hull is in solo second place on 16-under-par after a round of 67. The five-time LET winner, who fired a course round of -11 on day two, had nine birdies and three bogeys on her scorecard.

Ireland's Aine Donegan is in outright third place on 11-under-par after another round of 69 (-4). (PTI)

Basant, Shahnavaaz win India's maiden high jump, long jump medals in World Athletics U20 C'ships

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Eugene (USA)

Basant Kumar Meghwal and Shahnavaaz Khan became the first Indians to win a medal each in high jump and long jump at the World Athletics U20 Championships, clinching a silver and a bronze in their respective events on a memorable day for the country here.

The 19-year-old Basant, the reigning Asian U20 champion, cleared a personal-best of 2.21m to win the silver in the

men's high jump, while Shahnavaaz clinched the bronze in the men's long jump event with a best effort of 7.84m. Algeria's Younes Ayachi won the gold, while Great Britain's Otis Poole took the bronze.

All the three medallists could only clear 2.21m but failed all their three attempts to sail over 2.24m. The positions were thus decided on countback based on the number of attempts to clear the previous height.

Ayachi cleared 2.21m in his

first jump, while Meghwal and Poole did the same in their second and third attempts respectively.

Coached by former Indian women's high jump national record holder Sahana Kumari, Basant has made a remarkable 10cm improvement this season, raising his personal best from 2.11m to 2.21m. He won gold in the National Junior Fed Cup in 2025 and 2026, before bagging the Asian U20 Championships title in May this year.

Basant, currently employed



with the Indian Navy, hails from village 12 A-B near the

border town of Anupgarh in Sri Ganganagar district in

Rajasthan. Villages in border areas of Rajasthan are named using colonial-era irrigation block numbering system.

His farmer father Gangaram Meghwal, who also doubles up as driver and daily wage labourer, was the main driving force for Basant to take up sports.

Shahnavaaz shines with bronze in long jump India's medal tally then rose to three at the championships after Shahnavaaz clinched a bronze in the men's long jump with a best

effort of 7.84m. The 18-year-old produced his best jump in his third attempt, with his series reading 7.67m, 7.72m, 7.84m, 7.52m, 7.83m and 5.37m. Jithin Arjunan was the other Indian in the final, finishing eighth with a best jump of 7.59m.

Italy's Daniele Inzoli won the gold medal with a jump of 7.97m, while Australia's Mason McGroder took silver with a personal best of 7.96m.

The 18-year-old Shahnavaaz is one of the most promising long jumpers in the country

with Commonwealth Games silver medallist Murali Sreeshankar showering high praise on the youngster. He is the current national U20 record holder (8.30m) and reigning Asian U20 champion. He is currently third in the Asian senior top list of the season with his 8.30m jump while finishing behind Sreeshankar (8.38m) at the National Inter-State Championships in June. He won gold at the Asian U20 Championships in May with a jump of 7.84m.